

Hebrews: An Annotated Paraphrase

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Notes on this Paraphrase of Hebrews

This portion of God's Word, like every other portion, is practically inexhaustible in its richness. Obviously, a great deal could be said about it, and this paraphrase and commentary is intended only as a supplement to other resources¹. The comments that accompany this paraphrase will focus mainly on how the author of Hebrews uses the Old Testament (OT). Focusing on this subject will not only help up to understand Hebrews better than we did before, but will contribute to an understanding of the whole Bible, for seeing how the Holy Spirit led the author of Hebrews to interpret the OT passages cited in this letter will give us clues as to how to interpret other passages of Scripture.

The author of the book is unknown, though he was probably not an eyewitness of the earthly ministry of our Lord (2:3). He is exceedingly concise, and he constantly cites the OT in a way that he assumes his readers have (or will seek out) a detailed knowledge of the passage alluded to. The audience is also unknown, though it is likely one or more churches in Italy² (13:24).

I have not capitalized nouns or pronouns referring to God³, since the language in which the book of Hebrews was originally written did not use capitalization, and I think that artificial capitalization may interrupt the author's flow of thought. Italics function as they do in the King James Version and NASB, viz. indicating words not present in the original text. These added words attempt to bring out things implicit in the wording of the original and/or to clarify the flow of thought. The sign / indicates where a new line of Hebrew poetry begins. The symbol ʿ marks the beginning of the passage to which a footnote or endnote refers, and the number (in the case of footnotes) or letter(s) (in the case of endnotes) comes at the end of the passage to be commented on. For example, in 1:1, of the words “Having spoken ʿ in many portions and in many ways^a in days past to our *fore*-fathers in the prophets,” it is the words “in many portions and in many ways” that endnote “a” will discuss. Footnotes generally discuss how the author of Hebrews interprets the OT or clarify his logic. Endnotes generally cover material pertaining to translation issues or to material less directly related to passage found in Hebrews than the material found in the footnotes. The abbreviation “app.” means “appendix”; the appendixes can be found after the endnotes⁴.

¹ Some of the greatest aids are good translations, which should be read prayerfully, carefully, and repeatedly. I recommend the English Standard Version (ESV), the New American Standard Bible (NASB), Rotherham's Emphasized Bible, the International Standard Version (ISV), and the Holman Christian Standard Bible (HCSB).

Author's Note: This commentary is a light revision of an earlier version printed by Solid Rock Publications. As C. S. Lewis remarked with regard to one of his essays, sometimes one's writing from an early era is best left as-is. I'm not sure that this commentary ranks high in readability or how helpful its meandering discussions will prove, but perhaps there are some things of value in its notes. The close study of Scripture that writing it entailed all those years ago was certainly meaningful for my own soul.

² “Those from Italy greet you” probably means, “Those *travelers* who are *originally* from Italy send greetings home,” but it could also be taken to mean, “Those *with whom I am in contact* who live in Italy send greetings abroad.

³ Except for some nouns and proper nouns treated in English as names, especially, “Jesus,” “Christ,” and “God.”

⁴ Because of the complexity of the material contained in this volume, I would recommend that readers grapple with it in stages, perhaps reading only the main text to begin with, then, reading the main text with the footnotes, and finally reading the main text with the footnotes, endnotes, and appendixes.

Paraphrase of and Notes on Hebrews

1:1 Having spoken ‘in many portions and in many ways⁵ in days past to our *fore-fathers* in the prophets, **2** God has in these last days spoken to us in a son, whom he appointed heir of all *things*, through whom also he made the ‘ages⁶; **3** this son (being in quality the ‘eradiated brightness⁷ of his glory and the representation of his being and bearing everything by his powerful spoken word), having accomplished through himself cleansing for our sins *by his offering of himself as a perfect sacrifice on the cross*, sat down at the right hand of the majesty (*that is, God the Father*) in the exalted places *of heaven* – **4** having become superior to *all* the angels⁸ by just so much as he has inherited a more excellent name than they *have inherited*. **5** Indeed, to which of the angels has God the Father ever said *as he did in Ps 2:7*, “You are my son; / I this day have begotten you,” or similarly *spoken as he did in II Sam 7:14*, “I myself shall be a father to him⁹”? **6** Similarly, whenever he brings his firstborn into the world of men *as is referred to ‘Ps 97:7*¹⁰, he says, “And let all the angelic creatures of God worship him!”¹¹ **7** And on the one hand concerning angels he says *these words in ‘Ps 104:4*¹², “The one who makes his angels *into* winds, / and his servants *into* a flame of fire”; **8** on the other hand concerning the son *he says he these words in Ps 45:6*, “Your throne, O God, is forever!”¹³ and *in the next part of the same verse and in the next verse*, “A scepter of uprightness is the

⁵ I am unsure of the exact meaning of the Greek word translated “in many portions.” The ISV seems, however, to communicate the overall idea of this section well: “in fragmentary and varied fashion.” God revealed truth to mankind in the OT, but not in the full and clear way he did when he sent Jesus Christ.

⁶ Or perhaps “world” (ESV) or “universe” (ISV). The situation is similar in 11:3.

⁷ So Rotherham translates. (Most translations have simply “radiance”; ISV has “reflection.”) An ancient Aramaic paraphrase of Isaiah uses what may be the Aramaic equivalent of the Greek words “eradiated brightness of his glory” to explain the significance of the ends of the Lord’s robe mentioned in 6:1 of that book (see Cremer, Hermann, *Biblico-Theological Lexicon of New Testament Greek*, translated by William Urwick, 4th edition, Charles Scribner’s Sons, 1895). This expression, then, may be a Jewish one closely associated with the regal majesty of God.

⁸ Many Jews (and likely many Gentiles) overemphasized the importance of angels in the time period in which Hebrews was written, and this fact likely motivated the author to go out of his way to demonstrate their inferiority to Jesus.

⁹ This promise of fatherhood is given to male descendants of King David, whose privilege of sitting on the throne of Israel and enjoying this special relationship with God, however, had to be earned by righteous living (see II Sam 7:4-16). No descendant of David from Solomon onward fully earned this privilege (although in his grace God often kept a given king on the throne longer than that king deserved) until there came the righteous (and eternal) king prophesied in Is 9:6-7, Jesus Christ. The author of Hebrews brings all this Scriptural teaching together to say that Jesus has earned a special bond with the Father that no angel can claim.

¹⁰ Readers of Heb 1:6 attempting to identify the source of the quotation face a choice between a paraphrase of Ps 97:7 and Deut 32:43 in its Septuagint form (there is a textual variant in Deut 32:43). The correct choice becomes apparent when we take Rom 15:10 into consideration, since there Paul quotes Deut 32:43 in its Massoretic form, and therefore the author of Hebrews cannot be quoting the Septuagint form of that verse. As so often, comparing Scripture with Scripture clarifies matters: The author of Hebrews is citing Ps 97:7. (Note that the ESV has apparently overlooked Rom 15:10 in its consideration of Deut 32:43 and wrongly has adopted the Septuagint text there. Certainly, however, there are instances in which discerning the original text of Scripture is difficult, and we should be slow to condemn the efforts of others in this regard.)

¹¹ Since all angelic beings will one day bow before the son, we know that the son has inherited a better name than they have. (How does the author know that in Ps 97:7 “him” refers specifically to the son and not the father? Probably because the wording of Ps 97 is very similar to that of Ps 96 – many psalms seem to be grouped by similar form and/or content in pairs or in larger sets – and Ps 96 clearly refers to the son who has come to judge the worlds – see, for instance, Ps 2.)

¹² The ESV translates Ps 104:4 well (understanding “messengers” there to refer to angels; the Hebrew words for “messenger” and “angel” are the same); the HCSB, ISV, and NASB are either confusingly worded or mistranslated.

¹³ “God” in this quotation probably refers to God the Father. Another possibility is that the reference is to God the son, but this seems unlikely, for in the next verse of the psalm “God” clearly refers to God the father. Also, the

scepter of your kingdom. / **9** You have loved righteousness and hated iniquity; / therefore God, your God, has¹⁴ anointed you / with the oil of gladness ‘beyond¹⁵ your companions,” **10** and *he also says these words in Ps 102:25-27*, ‘“In the ancient times you, Lord, founded the earth, / And the heavens are the work of your hands. / **11** They will disappear, while you will endure; / And all of them as a garment will wear out, / **12** And as a cloak you will roll them up, / And they will be changed. / But you are the same, and your years will not end¹⁶.” **13** Now, concerning which of the angels did he ever say, *as he said concerning the son in Ps 110:1*, ‘“Sit at My right hand, / until I make your enemies / a footstool for your feet¹⁷”? **14** Are the angels not all *merely* serving spirits *designed* for giving aid *who are* sent out for the sake of those about to inherit salvation? **2:1** Therefore, *since it is in none other than Jesus Christ that God has spoken to us today (and not simply in angels)*, it is necessary that we pay closer attention to the things we have heard so that we will not drift away from what should be secure in our possession. **2** I sound this note of warning because if the message contained in the Mosaic Law ‘spoken through angels¹⁸ proved firm, and every act of transgression and disobedience received a just punishment, **3** ‘we certainly will not escape¹⁹ if we neglect so great a salvation, which, having begun by being spoken through the Lord *Jesus*, was confirmed to us by those who heard of it from him, **4** God at the same time testifying with them by signs and wonders and various miracles and gifts of the Holy Spirit which were distributed according to his own will.

2:5 After all, it was not to angels that he subjected the ‘coming world of men concerning which we

psalm seems to have as its immediate topic a king of Israel prior to Christ, Christ being the ultimate fulfillment of the ideas which the Holy Spirit expressed through the psalmists. If so, the psalmists would not label David or any of his descendants prior to Christ “God.” (It is not unusual in Hebrew poetry to shift abruptly from speaking to or about one person to speaking to or about another – see, for example, psalms 3 and 118.) See also the next quotation and the note on it.

¹⁴ The part of the psalm the author quoted already made reference to God the Father whose eternal reign gives him the right to delegate rule over Israel (and the rest of the earth) to whomever he chooses. In this part of the psalm we see the sovereign God selecting an individual whose upright character (specifically, one who loves righteousness and hates iniquity) mirrors his own. Kings of Israel from Solomon on only partly met this moral qualification and hence remained on the throne only temporarily, but Jesus has met it fully.

¹⁵ So ESV; the idea is probably well expressed in “rather than” (HCSB, ISV).

¹⁶ At first glance this quotation may appear to describe Jesus. Jesus was, in fact, as other Scripture shows, intimately involved in creation and is eternal. However, a closer look at the psalm quoted (102) seems to show that the person being addressed is God the father, not God the son. The language in this psalm is very similar to clear messianic psalms (such as 22). (Compare 102:10 with 40:12 and 118:18, where the idea seems likewise to be that the Messiah will bear the guilt of others' sins.) This fact suggests that it is not Jesus who is being spoken to; rather, Jesus is speaking (to the Father). Scripture as a whole seems to indicate, too, that prayer is made to God the father, not God the son. Jesus himself, we know, prayed fervently to the father (see, for example, Mt 26:39, Col 1:12, and Heb 5:7). What the author seeks to demonstrate by quoting from Ps 102, then, is likely that through prayer and recognition of God's character Jesus has a more intimate relationship with the Father than does any angel. The author has alluded to Christ's deity in the early verses of his book, but his emphasis here, and for much or all of the rest of the book, seems to be more on the accomplishments of Christ in his human nature than on the qualities inherent to his deity. (Incidentally, Scripture seems to treat the deity of Christ similarly to the triune character of the Godhead, assuming its truth throughout but not often seeing a need to defend it or to explain it in detail. Also note that the term “the Lord” in the OT can refer to at least two and probably to all three persons of the Godhead: for instance, in Is 61:1 it refers to the father, in Zech 14:16 it refers to the son, and in Jer 31:33 it evidently refers to the Holy Spirit, Heb 10:15 attributing this last prophecy to the spirit.)

¹⁷ See note to Eph 1:20 in *A Solid Rock Annotated Paraphrase of Ephesians*.

¹⁸ Although this fact is not discussed in detail in the OT, angels played some role in delivering the Mosaic Law to Israel (compare Deut 33:2, Acts 7:53, Gal 3:19, and perhaps Ps 68:17). (Another possibility is that the word translated “angels” here should be rendered “messengers” and be taken to refer to someone other than angelic beings – see Rotherham's translation here and his appendix entitled, “Messenger.”)

¹⁹ As the author will show throughout his epistle, we today are under the New Covenant rather than the Old Covenant, and the New Covenant brings with it greater responsibilities in addition to greater privileges.

speak²⁰. **6** Rather, someone testified somewhere – *specifically David in Ps 8:4-6* – saying, “What is man, that you remember him? / Or the son of man, that you concern yourself with him? / **7** you made him a little lower than ‘the angelic beings²¹; / Yet with glory and honor you crowned him²². / **8** All things you have put under his feet.” Consider *this passage we’ve just brought up*: In subjecting “all things” to him, he left nothing unsubjected. However, currently, *as we look around us at the natural world*, we don’t see all things subjected to him. **9** ‘But we do see him who was temporarily made a little lower than the angels²³ – ‘Jesus²⁴ – *who because of his willingness to undergo the suffering of death that he faced on the cross* ‘was crowned with glory and honor²⁵, so that by God’s grace toward us he might taste death on behalf of us all. **10** For it was fitting for him (through whom all things exist and for whom all things exist) in bringing many sons to glory to perfect the ‘founder²⁶ of their salvation through suffering. **11** For the one who sanctifies – *Jesus* – and the ones who are sanctified – *the sons we just referred to* – ‘are all out of one²⁷, for which reason Jesus is not ashamed to call them brothers, **12** saying in the messianic Ps 22 (in verse 22), “I will proclaim your name to my brothers; / In the midst of the assembly I will praise you in song,” **13** and similarly ‘in Is 12:2²⁸, ‘“I will put my trust in him²⁹,” and similarly in Is 8:18, ‘“Behold, I and the children whom God has given

²⁰ “The coming world of men” is almost certainly equivalent to a common Jewish term that signifies “the renovated earth under the reign of the Messiah” (in the wording of a note in Rotherham).

²¹ In Ps 8:5 some versions confuse matters by translating “God” rather than “the angels.” (In this case the King James Version is correct). The Hebrew word in question usually means “God,” but it can mean a number of other things, including “judges” (and such becomes important in Jn 10:34, where Jesus quotes Ps 82:6) and “angelic beings.” In Ps 8 contextual clues hint at the translation “angels,” and Hebrews demands it (the Greek word for angelic beings cannot mean “God”).

²² Ps 8 has “him, / And you have put him over the works of your hands,” but the author of Hebrews is quoting selectively, as authors often do today.

²³ The fact that part of this prophetic psalm has been fulfilled reassures us that the rest of it will as well, even though the present time has yet to see all the earth under man’s dominion.

²⁴ Is Ps 8:3-8 talking about mankind or about Jesus? I think the answer is, “Yes.” Man was created to rule over the animals of the earth (Gen 1:26), a passage which Ps 8 clearly draws on. No human, however, has yet achieved the comprehensive dominion over the earth that God had in mind. But God the son has become a man and in the future will achieve this sort of dominion. Others will reign concurrently with Christ (2 Tim 2:12), but he will lead the way. Thus we might call Jesus the ultimate man, a human who fulfills what it is to be human more than any of us ever will (and thus providing a role model for us in everything essential to being human). (A similar role of Christ is that of the ultimate Israel: Mat 2:15 sees Jesus’ sojourn in Egypt as making him experience what his nation did in the critical period of the Exodus – Hos 11:1. Similarly, Jesus better than any Jew fulfilled the Mosaic Law and became the light to the nations which Israel was supposed to be – cf. Is 42:5-9 and Mat 5:17.) See also app. 3.

²⁵ Jesus obeyed God the Father to a greater extent than any other man or woman has (or will) and will receive unmatched recognition for it. (Concerning this link between Jesus’ obedient death and his consequent exaltation see also Is 53:10-12 and Phil 2:8-9.)

²⁶ So ESV (HCSB translates “source”); another possibility is “pioneer” (ISV).

²⁷ A literal rendering of the Greek, the idea of which is probably “all have the same Father” (ISV), unless it is “all draw from the same source, *God the Father*.”

²⁸ It is difficult to say which OT text the author is citing. The precise Greek wording he uses is not found anywhere in the Septuagint (because the author of Hebrews is paraphrasing, because he here did his own translation from the Hebrew, or because our copies of the Septuagint contain an error), but two passages come very close – Is 12:2 and II Sam 22:3. Both of these seem plausible to me, though I lean towards saying that the author is citing Is 12:2.

²⁹ If Is 12:2 is being cited (see the previous endnote), the idea is probably that Jesus is there identified as part of the people of Israel (speaking on its behalf), and hence as uniquely close to and sympathetic with God’s people. Note that the second half of Is 12:2 is taken from Ex 15:2 (part of a song celebrating the nation of Israel’s deliverance from Egypt) and appears also in Ps 118:14 (a Messianic psalm), and because of the shared wording a first-century Jew may have been inclined to see all of these passages as conceptually linked (see also app. 1).

me³⁰.” **14** Since, then, the children have mortal bodies ‘in common³¹, he himself likewise became a partaker of a mortal body with them, so that through death he might ‘render powerless³² him who had the power of death (that is, the devil), **15** and might set free those who for fear of death lived all their lives under slavery. **16** For certainly he does not help angels – rather, he helps the offspring of Abraham, **17** for which reason he needed to become like his brothers in every way, so that he could become a merciful and faithful high priest ‘in service to God³³ in order to make propitiation for the sins of the people; **18** for in that which he himself suffered, having been tempted, he is able to give aid to those who are being tempted.

3:1 So then, my holy brothers, partakers of a heavenly calling, consider the apostle and high priest of our confession – Jesus, **2** who was faithful to the one who appointed him to his role, just as Moses also was faithful to God in all the proper administration of ‘God’s³⁴ house. **3** ‘To explain further what we have in mind in bringing up Christ and Moses³⁵: ‘God³⁶ deserves greater glory than Moses deserves by just so much as the builder of a house has greater honor than the house **4** (every house, after all, is built by someone, but ultimately, the builder of all things is God), **5** and Moses on the one hand was faithful in all his house as a servant, as God says in Num 12:7 (for a witness of the things which were to be spoken), **6** but Christ on the other hand was faithful ‘as a son³⁷ over his house – whose house we are, if (and only if) we hold on firmly to our confidence and to ‘the hope in which we rejoice³⁸ until the end.

3:7 Therefore, just as the Holy Spirit says in Ps 95:7-11, “Today if you hear his voice, / **8** Do not harden your hearts as in the rebellion, / As on the day of testing in the wilderness, / **9** When your fore-fathers tested me; they put me to the test, / Though they had seen my works for forty years. / **10** For this reason I was angry with that generation, / And I said, ‘They always go astray in heart, / And they have not understood my ways;’ / **11** As I swore in my anger: / Surely they will not enter into my rest.” **12** Watch out, my brothers, so that there may not be in any of you a wicked, unbelieving heart that turns away from the living God – **13** rather, be exhorting one another day by day, ‘as long as it is called “today³⁹,” in order that

³⁰ (It is common practice in this type of literature to quote only part of a passage when referring to the whole thing. The whole sentence in Is 8:18 is, “Behold, I and the children the Lord has given me are for signs and wonders in Israel.”) For a larger context for the quotation, see Is 7:1-9:6. God gave Isaiah three sons (see app. 1) whose names communicated prophetic truth to the people, and so Isaiah put them on the same level as himself. The author of Hebrews, then, mindful that Jesus is the ultimate prophet (see note on “Jesus” in Heb 2:9 and compare Deut 18:15-22 with Jn 8:28 and 12:49-50), observes that Christ is willing to include others as partners in his ministry. (Another possible reason for applying this passage to Christ is the use of the word “disciple” – a word which is very rare in the OT but frequently used in describing the ministry of Christ – shortly before Is 8:16. See also app. 1.)

³¹ So HCSB.

³² So NASB (Rotherham has “paralyse”); the ESV, HCSB, and ISV have “destroy.”

³³ So HSCB and ISV (ESV is similar); Rotherham “in the things pertaining to God” (NASB is similar). (The same expression occurs in 5:1.)

³⁴ Literally, “his.” (That the house belongs to God and not to Moses is apparent from the general argument and from the allusion the author will shortly make to Num 12:7, in which God says, “Not so is my servant Moses: in all my house he is faithful.” See also Heb 10:21.)

³⁵ Or perhaps “For,” but the Greek word used here, though it can signify things like “for,” can also be used to transition from the introduction of a topic to the details of that topic, and such a transition seems to fit the context.

³⁶ Or perhaps “Christ”; literally, “this one” (an expression which in Greek is often used in cases where English would say “he,” “she,” or “it”).

³⁷ The son of a landowner has greater responsibility, permanence, and authority than a mere servant has. Thus Jesus is a more authoritative and more proven leader to follow than is Moses (and the OT laws and systems which are associated with him). We should, then, be careful to obey Jesus as our leader (even more careful than we would be to obey Moses if we were Israelites living in the time period of the exodus) and strive to follow his example of faithfulness to God (which was subject to a greater level of accountability than was Moses’ faithfulness).

³⁸ So ISV; NASB is more literal with “the boast of our hope.”

³⁹ Exhorting one another to endeavor to enter that rest is something we should not put off until tomorrow.

none of you may be hardened by the deceitfulness of sin **14** (for we have become partakers of Christ if we should hold on to the beginning of our commitment firm until the end), **15** in that it is said, “Today if you hear his voice, / Do not harden your hearts as in the rebellion.” **16** Who was it, after all, who rebelled even though they had heard *God’s voice*? Was it not, in point of fact, all those who came out of Egypt through *the ministry of Moses*? **17** Now, with whom was God angry for forty years? Was it not indeed with those of *the Israelites who left Egypt* who sinned, whose dead bodies fell *to the ground* in the wilderness? **18** And concerning whom did he swear that they could not enter his rest, if not those who proved disobedient? **19** And *thus* we see that that generation of *Israelites* was unable to enter *into the rest which Ps 95 mentions* because of unbelief. **4:1** Let us fear, then, in order that, while promise of entering his rest *still* remains, any of you should seem to be falling short of *attaining that promise*. **2** We too, after all, have had *the good news concerning this rest* preached to us, in just the manner that they themselves did (but the word they heard did not profit them, ‘because they were not united by faith with those who listened to it’⁴⁰); **3** we who have believed enter into *this* rest, just as he said, “As I swore in my anger, / Surely they will not enter into my rest” (*which statement implies that those who do believe will enter his rest*), even though his works have stood completed since the foundation of the world. **4** To explain *why I say “even though”*: ‘Scripture’⁴¹ has spoken in this manner somewhere with reference to the sabbath (*to be specific, in Gen 2:2*): “And God rested on the seventh day from all his works,” ‘showing us that God has already entered into rest’⁴², **5** and yet in this passage (Ps 95) we observe again that it says, “Surely they will not enter into my rest,” *implying that those who obediently believe God will enter his rest at some future point*. **6** Since, then, it remains for some *people* to enter into it, and those who formerly had *this* good news preached to them did not enter because of *their* unbelief, **7** it again determines a *certain* day, *namely* “today,” speaking much later in ‘*the writer of Ps 95, David*’⁴³, as said *before*, “Today if you hear my voice, / Do not harden your hearts.” **8** (For if Joshua had given them rest *when he led them into the land of Canaan*, ‘David’⁴⁴ would not have spoken in *his psalm* of ‘another’⁴⁵ day after that.) **9** So there remains a sabbath rest for the people of God, **10** ‘for the individual who enters into his rest has himself rested from his works just as God *rested* from his own works

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⁴⁰ So the ISV translates, with the ESV being similar. The HCSB follows the same manuscripts as the ESV and ISV but interprets some of the verses in this section differently than I do. (Other manuscripts have “because it was not united by faith in those who heard,” as the NASB renders.)

⁴¹ Or “God” (if so, translate “he again determines” instead of “it again determines” in 4:7).

⁴² When in Ps 95 God spoke of “my rest,” he did not mean that he himself would rest at some future point. The author of Hebrews reminds us, after all, that Gen 2 says that God completed “all his work” and accordingly “rested on the seventh day.” So, while the author will go on to show from Scripture that our rest still lies ahead of us, God’s rest is past, and the fact that it is long since past makes it all the more remarkable (hence the author’s words “even though” above) that we can enter God’s rest.

⁴³ The author of Hebrews knew that David was the author of Ps 95, even though the Hebrew manuscripts of the Psalms we possess today do not record an author for that psalm. The Septuagint translation indicates David as the author, either because it in that place had access to better Hebrew manuscripts than we have, or (as I suspect) because it was drawing on oral tradition, tradition shown to be accurate in this instance by Scripture’s corroboration of it (see app. 4).

⁴⁴ Literally, “he” (meaning David) or “it” (meaning the Scriptures).

⁴⁵ Although Ps 95 speaks of the generation of Israelites that left Egypt, the rest that they were denied was not entrance into the land of Canaan (which Joshua provided for the subsequent generation). We can discern this because David, who lived several generations after Joshua and the others entered Canaan, warns his readers of the need to be diligent to enter that rest, using the word “today.” Evidently, David was referring to a different kind of rest than the entrance into Canaan, land that the Israelites of his day already lived on.

⁴⁶ As was noted above, our entering into God’s rest does not mean that we and he rest at the same time, since God rested already back in Gen 2 (several thousand years before we were even born). Rather, it means that we, having completed whatever tasks God has laid out for us in this life (compare Eph 2:10), partake in the next life of the sort of rest that God partook of, having completed the tasks he had set out for himself (in Gen 1). What a profound truth

4:11 Let us be diligent, then, to enter into that rest, in order than none may fall by following the pattern of disobedience *we see in the Israelites who left Egypt*. **12** The word of God, after all, is living and capable and sharper than any two edged sword, ‘piercing until it divides soul and spirit, joints and marrow⁴⁷, and able to ‘judge⁴⁸ the thoughts and intentions of the heart, **13** and no created thing is *able to remain* hidden in ‘his⁴⁹ presence, but *rather* everyone is naked and ‘exposed⁵⁰ before his eyes, ‘concerning whom we are speaking,⁵¹ *and so if we are negligent with respect to the opportunity to enter this rest, that negligence will not be overlooked*.

4:14 Having, then, a great high priest (*as we mentioned earlier*), who has passed through the heavens, *namely* Jesus the son of God, let us hold on to our confession. **15** We do not, after all, have a high priest *who is* unable to sympathize with our weakness, but one *who has been* tempted in every way just as we *have been tempted* without ever giving in to temptation's demands and sinning. **16** Let us draw near with confidence, then, to the throne of grace, in order that we may receive mercy and find grace ‘to help us in our time of need⁵². **5:1** Now, *to begin to consider Christ's high priesthood in more detail*: every Levitical high priest ‘taken from among men⁵³ is appointed on behalf of *other men* in service to God in order that he might offer gifts and sacrifices *to God* on behalf of sins. *Such a high priest is 2* able to deal gently with the ignorant and erring, since ‘he himself is beset with weakness, *often giving in to the temptation to sin 3* (and for this reason it is necessary *for him* to offer sacrifices for sin for himself also⁵⁴ just as for the people). **4** And no one takes for himself this honor *of being a high priest* but rather is called *to the position* by God, in just the same way as Aaron also *was appointed to the high priesthood by God in Ex 28:1*. **5** So also Christ did not glorify himself so as to be made a high priest *at his own demand*, but rather the one who spoke to him *exalted him to the high priesthood when he said in Ps 2:7*, ‘“You are my son, / I this day have begotten you⁵⁵,” **6** just as he says in another place (*namely, Ps 110:4*), ‘“You are a priest forever according to the order of Melchizedek⁵⁶.” **7** *Indeed*, Jesus ‘in the days of his flesh⁵⁷ offered urgent requests, and supplications as well, with a great cry and tears to the one who was able to save him from death, and *he* was

to meditate on and by God's grace to live out! See also app. 3.

⁴⁷ So ISV.

⁴⁸ So most translations; NASB “discern.”

⁴⁹ The Greek can also be translated “its.” I think, though, that the word of God spoken of here is not the Bible but rather Christ (note such passages as Jn 1:1 and Rev 19:13), because the description here seems similar to such Bema passages as I Cor 3:11-15, 4:5, and II Cor 5:10, and because the words “concerning whom we are speaking” (but see the endnote on those words) seem to fit Christ better than the Bible, for Christ more than the Bible as such seems to constitute one of the major themes of this book.

⁵⁰ So most translations; ISV “helpless.”

⁵¹ Or “concerning which we are speaking.” HCSB and ESV have “to whom we must give an account” (ISV is similar), but a very similar expression in 5:11 seems to point to the translation given above.

⁵² So ISV.

⁵³ The idea is probably that the high priest understands full well what challenges fellow human beings face in their lives because he spends the majority of his life living day to day life among ordinary people. No one is born a Levitical high priest, after all, and the high priests of Israel did not spend their whole lives secluded in a monastery.

⁵⁴ The author brings up this characteristic of the Levitical high priest because later (7:27) he will contrast it with Christ.

⁵⁵ The emphasis in Ps 2 (clearly a Messianic psalm) is on Christ being king. Why, then, does the author cite it to prove that Christ was designated a priest? Perhaps ideally a king should also be a priest, as was Melchizedek (Gen 14:18). Alternatively or in addition, since we know from Ps 110 that the messiah will be a priest, the messiah's designation as king implies a similar designation as priest.

⁵⁶ As noted above, this type of literature sometimes quotes only part of an OT passage to which it refers. The whole verse the author is citing reads, “The Lord has sworn and will not change his mind, *saying*, ‘You are a priest forever according to the order of Melchizedek.’” It is clear, then, that the words “You are a priest” do not mean “You have made yourself a priest,” but rather, “I have designated you a priest.”

⁵⁷ We might paraphrase, “when he lived on the earth.”

heard ‘because of his devotion to the things of God, *not because of anything intrinsic to his nature*. **8** Even though he was a son of *God*, he learned obedience from the things he suffered⁵⁸, **9** and having been made complete he became a source of eternal salvation to all who obey him, **10** having been named by God a high priest according to the order of Melchizedek – **11** pertaining to whom we have much to say, and it is difficult *for us* to explain *it*, since you have become lazy when it comes to listening *to things of God*.

5:12 I say this *about your being lazy when it comes to listening* because even though you should certainly be teachers on account of the *substantial amount of time you have been Christians*, you again have need of someone to teach you the basic principles of the beginning *truths* of the oracles of God, *the Bible*, and you have come to be in need of milk *again* and not solid food. **13** Now, the one who partakes of *only spiritual* milk is inexperienced in *living out the truth of* the word of righteousness, *the Bible* (he is a *only a spiritual* child, after all), **14** but *spiritual* solid food belongs to the mature, *that is*, to those whose ‘minds⁵⁹ have been trained by practice to discern good and evil.

6:1 Therefore, leaving behind discussion of the *mere* beginning of *Scriptural teaching* concerning Christ, let us move on to maturity, not again laying a foundation of repentance from dead works and faith in God, **2** teaching concerning immersions, and laying on of hands, and the resurrection of the dead and eternal judgment. **3** And let us *leave behind these basic topics for more involved ones*, if indeed God permits. **4** *I again sound a note of warning* because *in the case of* those who once have been enlightened, and have also tasted of the heavenly gift, and have become partakers of the Holy Spirit, **5** and tasted of the good ‘word of God⁶⁰ and also the powers of the coming age, **6** and *yet subsequently* have gone astray, it is impossible to renew *them* again to repentance, since they are again crucifying for themselves the son of God and publicly disgracing him. **7** For that soil which has drunk the rain falling on it many times and produces vegetation *which is* useful to those *individuals* for whose sake it was planted in the first place receiving blessing from God, **8** but that *soil* which grows thorns and thistles is unfit *for its very purpose* and is close to being cursed, ‘and in the end it will be burned⁶¹. **9** But we are sure, beloved, of things that are better for you and connected to salvation, even though we speak in such a *serious* manner – **10** God, after all, is not unrighteous so as to forget your work and the labor of love which you have shown for his name, since you have served the saints and are *still* serving *the saints* – **11** but *we do see a need to speak in a serious manner* because we desire that each one of you show the same diligent attentiveness to *achieving* the certainty *you ought to have* of your hope until the end of *your earthly lives* **12** in order that you may not become *spiritually* lazy, but *instead* become imitators of those who through faith and patience were inheriting the promises.

6:13 ‘What I mean *by referring to “promises”* is this: when God made his promise to Abraham *in Gen 22:16-18*, since he could swear by no one greater *than himself*, he *indeed* swore by himself, **14** saying, “Surely I will greatly bless you, and I will greatly multiply you.” **15** (And in this way Abraham through ‘*his exhibition of patience when he proved willing to undergo the trial of sacrificing Isaac in Gen 22* ‘attained

⁵⁸ True, Jesus was the son of God and thus utterly perfect and unable to sin. Yet, the author points out, he lived his life on earth by means of the same tools we today have – access to God the Father through prayer and the trials which God brings into our life to help us mature (Jm 1:2-4). (Also common to Jesus and to us are the Holy Spirit's presence and the Bible – see, for example, Mat 3:16-4:11. Note, too, the displeasure with favoritism that God demonstrates in Deut 21:15-17 (as Pastor Brian Demers has pointed out in personal communication to the present writer). This concept is relevant here because God the father did not give his special son, Jesus, an easier life than any other human had experienced or would experience.)

⁵⁹ So ISV.

⁶⁰ Or “Word of God,” but the Greek wording here may indicate that the author has in mind not the Bible specifically, but rather any instance of the sovereign God's declaration in action (Rotherham translates “God's utterance”), such as seeing an answer to prayer or recognizing a biblical promise of God coming to fruition in actual experience. I Pet 1:23-25 may be expressing a similar idea, describing God's salvation as God's declaration (or “word,” as most translations have it there – Rotherham has “declaration”).

⁶¹ So ISV. The imagery here may be of a thicket-covered piece of land deliberately set on fire so as to clear it.

the promise.) **16** For men swear by something greater than themselves, *as when a man swears by the Temple* (and, *thus reinforced by the authority of something great*, the oath provides a confirmation of goodwill for every dispute). **17** God, because he decided to show his decision's unchanging character to those who are inheriting the promise, guaranteed *his own promise* with an oath **18** 'so that through two unchangeable things (in which it is impossible for God to lie) – *namely, though God's promise and his oath by himself* – we might have a strong encouragement, *we* who are taking refuge in order to take hold of the hope that lies before us, **19** *a hope* which we have as an anchor for the soul, firm and strong and entering into the place within the veil (*that is, into the holy of holies*), **20** into which Jesus went as a forerunner on our behalf, having become a high priest according to the order of Melchizedek.

7:1 To proceed with our topic, *which we began earlier*, this Melchizedek, King of Salem, a priest of God Most High, who met Abraham in *Gen 14:17-20* when he was returning *home* from defeating the kings (*who had earlier defeated Sodom and Gomorrah and left with all their treasures*) and blessed him – **2** to whom also Abraham gave a tithe of all *the treasures he had captured in the war* – 'This important man, Melchizedek, is first, *when we translate the meaning of his Hebrew name*, "the king of righteousness," and second, also the king of Salem, which is to say "the king of peace" ("*Salem*" being the Hebrew word for "peace")⁶². **3** 'Having no father, having no mother, having no genealogy, having neither a beginning of days nor an end of life but made to resemble the son of God, *Jesus*,⁶³ 'he remains a priest continually⁶⁴. **4** Now consider how great this priest is to whom Abraham – the patriarch – gave a tithe of the treasures he had captured. **5** And on the one hand those of the sons of Levi who receive the *ministry of priesthood* have a commandment *given for their benefit that says* that the people of *Israel*, that is, their brothers, according to the *Mosaic Law* are to give a tithe *to the levites*, even though they came from the loins of Abraham *just like the levites did*, **6** but this one who does not descend from them, *Melchizedek*, received tithes from Abraham, and *moreover* blessed *Abraham*, the one who had the promises of *God* **7** (and beyond all dispute, the lesser person is blessed by the greater, *and so we see that Melchizedek is greater even than Abraham, the forefather of the people of Israel and the forefather, according to the flesh, of Christ*). **8** 'And on the one hand in this case dying men receive tithes, but on the other hand in that case it is testified that he lives⁶⁵. **9**

⁶² Thus, by examining Melchizedek's name and title, the author finds Melchizedek to be characterized by righteous behavior, associated with peace, and royal (this last characteristic, at least, contrasting him with the Levitical priests, who were not chosen by God to be kings).

⁶³ The author does not describe Melchizedek and Christ as being the same person. I see at least three reasons why the two are distinct. The author says here that Melchizedek is like (not identical to) Christ and later in verse 15 that Christ is like Melchizedek. In verse 16 he will speak of Christ becoming a priest rather than as having been one since eternity past. Whatever sacrifices Melchizedek made as priest, these sacrifices did not have the sufficiency which Christ's later sacrifice of himself did (or else the cross would have been unnecessary). (This last reason may be why the author refers to Christ as a high priest according to the order of Melchizedek but to Melchizedek himself only as a priest; while the emphasis in this passage is on the greatness of Melchizedek, the author, I think, subtly indicates Melchizedek's inferiority in comparison to Christ.) Rather, the author seems to be thinking along these lines: Ordinarily, key biblical figures (not to mention many minor ones) have their father recorded, their mother recorded, a genealogy provided, their birth mentioned, their death mentioned, or some combination of these elements. For Melchizedek, however, Scripture provides no such information. What it does give us is a portrait of a man who resembles Christ and from whose story we can accordingly learn more about Christ's role and importance.

⁶⁴ Melchizedek appears only twice in the OT (Gen 14 and Ps 110), and in both the focus is on his being a priest. Since Scripture puts so much emphasis on Melchizedek's priesthood, the author reasons, we ought to take a closer look at it, which is what the author proceeds to do.

⁶⁵ (The idea behind "dying men" is likely "mortal men.") Probably "this case" refers to the Levitical priesthood and "that case" to the priesthood which Melchizedek held in the days of Abraham, Melchizedek being one whose death is not recorded, anticipating Christ whom death would not hold captive, whereas Aaron's death is recorded (Num 33:38), and it is obvious that every Levitical priest thereafter eventually died. Or "this case" may refer to the case of the Levitical priesthood (or the Levitical and Melchizedekian priesthoods together) and "that case" to Christ, the author anticipating the point he will shortly make that Jesus will never die.

And in a manner of speaking even *the tribe of Levi* which receives tithes through Abraham paid this tithe, **10** because he was still in the loins of his father, *Abraham*, when Melchizedek met him.

7:11 If, then, perfection had come through the Levitical priesthood (the people *of Israel*, after all, received the *Mosaic* Law on that basis), what further need would there be for a different priest to arise, *a priest* designated after the order of Melchizedek and not after the order of Aaron? **12** (Indeed, a change in the priesthood necessarily involves a change in the law as well.) **13** After all, he concerning whom we are saying these things became a partaker of a different tribe *than the one Aaron, the first Levitical priest, partook of, a tribe* from which no one ministered at the altar. **14** For it is evident that *it was from the tribe of Judah that our lord Jesus Christ descended*, concerning which tribe Moses said nothing *in the Pentateuch* about priesthood. **15** And this *fact – that Jesus descended from a tribe other than Levi* – is even more clearly evident if a different priest arises according to the likeness of Melchizedek **16** who ‘has become a priest, not on the basis of a legal requirement concerning bodily descent⁶⁶ but rather on the basis of the power of an indestructible life. *And we know that his life is indestructible* **17** since it is testified in *Ps 110:4* that “You are a priest forever (*that is, never to die*), according to the order of Melchizedek.” *Thus we see that perfection could not come through the Levitical priesthood, since a priest of another tribe was coming, and this fact entailed the cancellation of the Mosaic Law at a certain point in time.* **18** (Indeed, on the one hand, the previous commandment *for priests to descend from the proper ancestor within the tribe of Levi* is canceled because of its weakness and unprofitableness – **19** the *Mosaic* Law (*of which this requirement was a part*), after all, did not perfect anything – but on the other hand, the entrance of a better hope, through which we draw near to God, is *now* available.) **20** Furthermore, *Jesus’ Melchizedekian priesthood is shown to be superior to the levites’ Aaronic priesthood* in that it was not enacted without an oath – for the Levitical priests on the one hand have *all* become priests without an oath, **21** but Jesus on the other hand *became a priest* with an oath through the one who spoke to him in *Ps 110:4*, saying, “The Lord has sworn and will not change his mind, *saying, / ‘You are a priest forever according to the order of Melchizedek’*” – **22** and by just so much *as having had his priesthood confirmed with God’s oath in this way*, Jesus has become the guarantee of an even better covenant *than the Levitical priests were.* **23** Still further, the *Levitical* priests of the *OT* on the one hand were many *in number* because they were prevented by death from continuing in *their ministry*, **24** but he on the other hand, because he remains forever, holds the priesthood permanently, **25** for which reason he is also able to save completely those who through him draw near to God, always living so as to make intercession on their behalf. **26** For it was fitting for us to have such a high priest, ‘who has become pious, without evil, undefiled, kept apart from sinners, and exalted above the heavens⁶⁷, **27** who has no need to offer sacrifices daily, as *did* the *Levitical* high priests, first offering a sacrifice on behalf of their own sins *and only then offering sacrifices* on behalf of the people, because this high priest has done this once for all when he offered himself *as a sacrifice on the cross.* **28** For the *Mosaic* Law appoints men as high priests who are imperfect *with respect to offering sacrifices on behalf of the sins of others*, but the word of the oath *we alluded to earlier that comes after the cancellation of the Mosaic Law appoints* a son who has been made perfect – *Jesus.*

8:1 The main point in what we have been saying is that we have such a high priest, who has sat down at the right hand of the throne of the majesty in the heavenly places, **2** *who is* a minister of the holy place and of the true Tabernacle, *the Tabernacle* ‘which the Lord pitched and not man⁶⁸. **3** Now, every high

⁶⁶ So ESV (most versions are similar). Levitical priests could only be priests because they traced their descent to Aaron (while Jesus’ right to be a priest is grounded on his eternal life).

⁶⁷ Most versions seem to understand the Greek similarly, but another possibility is “*who is pious, without evil, undefiled, kept apart from sinners, and has become exalted above the heavens*” (to which Rotherham is similar). The Greek word here translated “pious” could possibly be rendered “holy,” but in this context “pious” is probably the best English word available, “dutiful” and “virtuous” expressing related ideas.

⁶⁸ The author is probably citing Num 24:6, in which the word “aloes” (which most English translations have) should probably be translated as “the true tent” or “tents” and “planted” as “pitched.” (The words “gardens beside a river”

priest is appointed for offering both gifts and sacrifices. For this reason it is necessary that he himself have something to offer. *We will see just what is was that Jesus had to offer shortly.*

8:4 If in fact Christ was on the earth *during OT times*, he would not have been a priest, since there are priests *already (the levites)* who bear gifts *and sacrifices* according to the *Mosaic Law* – **5** *namely, the Levitical priests* (who minister in *what is only* ‘a copy and a shadow of the heavenly places, just as Moses was warned when he was about to construct the Tabernacle: “See to it,” God said in *Ex 25:40*, “that you do everything according to the pattern that was shown to you on the mountain⁶⁹”) – **6** but now he has attained a more excellent ministry, by just so much as he is the mediator of a better covenant *than the Mosaic Law*, a *better covenant* which was enacted on better promises. **7** I say this *about “better” promises* because if that first covenant (*the Mosaic Law*) ‘had been faultless, there would have been no reason to seek a second, **8** but in fact, finding fault *with those who were under the first covenant* he says to them⁷⁰ in *Jer 31:31-34*, “Behold, days are coming,” says the Lord, ‘When I will make a new covenant with the house of Israel and with the house of Judah, **9** not according to the covenant which I made with their *fore-fathers* in the day I took them by the hand and led them out of the land of Egypt, for they did not remain true to my covenant, *but instead sinned against me many times*, and I in turn ‘rejected them⁷¹,’ says the Lord. **10** ‘For this is the *new covenant* which I will make with them after those days,’ says the Lord, ‘putting ‘my laws⁷² in their mind – and on their *very heart* will I write them, and *then* I will *truly* be to them a *personal God*, and they will *truly* be to me a people. **11** And *in that day* they will not be teaching each one his neighbor and each one his brother, saying, “Get to know the Lord,” *because they will have no need to do this*, for all *people* will know me, from the least of them to the greatest of them. **12** For I will be merciful to their iniquities, and of their sins and of their lawless deeds I will be mindful no longer.” **13** When he says, “*I will make a new covenant*,” he makes the first covenant obsolete. (Now, *obviously*, something that has been made obsolete is aging and near to *total disappearance*.)

9:1 Even the first *covenant*, then, had regulations for ministry and an earthly holy place. **2** Indeed, a

in the same verse in the ESV could be rendered “like the Garden of Eden that was beside the Euphrates.”) In that passage, then, we see Balaam complimenting the nation of Israel by saying that its dwelling places can be compared to the dwelling place of God. What the author of Hebrews notices is that this comparison implies that God has a Tabernacle (neither Hebrew nor Greek have a word for “Tabernacle,” using instead a word meaning “tent” or “dwelling place”) distinct from that which the Israelites built.

⁶⁹ The word “pattern” implies that Moses saw some representation of the true Tabernacle in heaven, and that the Tabernacle of Israel (and, by extension, the later Temple of Solomon, rebuilt still later by Zerubbabel) was a small earthly version of the true Tabernacle (see also 9:24 below, and 8:2 above and the note there). (It is also possible that the words “see to it that you do” in the present passage and in *Ex 25:30* should be translated “behold *this pattern*. You shall do,” implying the existence of a heavenly Tabernacle of which the earthly was a small model.) The author notes that although the Tabernacle Moses built was certainly glorious, the Tabernacle on which it was modeled was surely more glorious.

⁷⁰ The flaw with the Mosaic Law was not something inherent in the Law itself, Rather, the people subjected to it could never (and did never) properly fulfill its demands by their own strength. See also *Rom 7:4-12*.

⁷¹ The English versions of *Jer 31:32* are different. This is a slight chance of a textual variant in that verse (in which case the author of Hebrews has followed the correct reading), but more likely the Hebrew word in question can signify a different idea than that recognized by most translators of the OT (in which case the author of Hebrews has translated the Hebrew word correctly, whereas most English versions have not).

⁷² (English versions of *Jer 31:33* generally translate “law,” but this translation presupposes a wrong set of vowels for the word – Hebrew writing did not show most vowels, leaving them for the reader to infer. The present passage of Hebrews proves that the vowels should be that of the word for “laws.”) To see this word in the plural in the OT is unusual, and it may be reminiscent of *Gen 26:5*, where the word is similarly plural and is clearly not used in reference to the one and only Mosaic Law and the set of stipulations specific to Israel contained within it (since it is used with reference to the patriarchs, who lived before the Mosaic Law was given at Mt. Sinai). The reference seems to be to the various character traits that naturally flow from an understanding of who God in his holiness is.

tent was prepared: the first ‘tent’⁷³, in which were both the lampstand and the table and the bread of the presence (*the entrance to the tent being covered over with a curtain*), which *first tent* is called “the Holy Place.” **3** Beyond the second curtain was a tent which was called “the Holy of Holies,” **4** ‘having associated with it a golden altar of incense’⁷⁴, and the ark of the covenant covered with gold on all sides, ‘in which *Holy of Holies*’⁷⁵ ‘was a golden jar containing the manna which God told Moses and Aaron to keep there as a testimony to future generations, and the rod of Aaron that budded in vindication of Aaron’s priesthood, and the tablets on which were written the Ten Commandments, which were the first commandments of the Old Covenant given’⁷⁶. **5** Now above it were the cherubim of glory overshadowing the mercy seat. (Concerning these subjects we will not speak in detail at this time.) **6** These things having been prepared in this way, the priests would constantly enter the first tent – *that is, the Holy Place* – while fulfilling their ministerial duties, **7** but the second tent – *that is, the Holy of Holies* – the high priest alone would enter *only* once a year, and *that only with a sacrifice involving the shedding of blood*, which he offered on behalf the ‘unintentional sins’⁷⁷ which *both* he and the people committed, **8** the Holy Spirit *by this arrangement of things in the Tabernacle* indicating this, *that the way to enter freely the Holy of Holies has not yet become a reality for as long as the first tent remains*, **9** which *first tent* is symbolic of the ‘present period of time’⁷⁸, in which both

⁷³ By “tent” (here and several times following) the author may mean “a portion of the tent,” and so the ESV, HCSB, and ISV seem to understand.

⁷⁴ Notice that the author does not say that the altar of incense was within the Holy of Holies (it was not), but simply associated with it. He likely makes this association (rather than grouping the altar of incense with the Holy Place) because he notices the OT doing the same thing: Although the altar of incense indeed is in the Holy Place, Ex 30:6 describes it as “in front of the” mercy seat on the ark (rather than “in the Holy Place”), and Lev 16:13 describes the cloud of incense from the altar as wafting over the mercy seat. The author’s attention to detail thus yields the insight that to understand the Holy of Holies fully will involve a study of the altar of incense as well as the ark of the covenant, the items within it, and the cherubim.

⁷⁵ So, in effect, Pastor Alan Brown’s translation (given in a session at a Shepherds’ Haven conference). Other translations render in effect “in which *ark*,” but Ex 16:33 and Num 17:10 call for the jar and the staff, respectively, to be placed “in front of” (not “in”) the ark of the covenant, and I Kings 8:9 tells us that when the ark was placed in Solomon’s Temple, the tablets alone were contained within it. While the author may be speaking of a time between the time of Num 17 and I Kings 8 in which these items were in fact contained within the ark (later to be removed), this seems unlikely.

⁷⁶ The author does not mention the Pentateuch in his list of things contained within the Holy of Holies, although Dt 31:26, on first reading at least, would seem to say that the original copy of the Pentateuch was there as well. However, the Pentateuch may have been housed for safe keeping along with the ark only temporarily, until the people of Israel could be assembled (see verse 28) to hear the song of chapter 32 (31:30). Note that later (Josh 24:26) Joshua would add the book bearing his name to the scroll containing the Pentateuch, something he probably could not do, since he was an Ephraimite and consequently could never have been a high priest (who alone had the right to enter the Holy of Holies). Probably, then, while the tablets containing the Ten Commandments were indeed housed in the Holy of Holies, the scroll containing the Pentateuch was not a permanent feature of that portion of the Tabernacle, and this reality the author of Hebrews accurately reflects in his list.

⁷⁷ So ESV (and some of the other versions may be interpreted as communicating the same idea). Although the day of atonement (that one day on which the high priest would enter the Holy of Holies, described in Lev 16) involved atonement for all the Israelites’ sins (both intentional and unintentional), when the high priest brought blood to the mercy seat (the part of the day of atonement that the author of Hebrews is thinking of here) it was for the unintentional sins of the people. The author again shows special attention to detail. (Why was it specifically for unintentional sins that the high priest entered the most holy part of the Tabernacle? I am not sure, but my guess would be that it is in the matter of unintentional sins that humans need God’s grace the most. After all, for every one intentional sin that would be charged to our account apart from Christ’s intervention, there are probably several instances in which we unintentionally have fallen short of God’s standard. For at least a somewhat similar thought – that and even when we desire to do the right thing we so often fail anyway – cf. Mt 26:41.)

⁷⁸ That is, the period of time under discussion, the period of time (most of the OT) in which the Mosaic Law was in force.

gifts and sacrifices are being offered which cannot perfect the conscience of the one ‘worshiping’⁷⁹ at the Tabernacle, **10** these gifts and sacrifices and the various stipulations of the Mosaic Law associated with them dealing only with such merely external matters as food, drink, and various immersions, which are regulations of the flesh which remain required until a time of reformation.

9:11 When Christ appeared, however, as a high priest of the coming good things, through a greater and more perfect tent not made with hands (that is, a tent which is not of this creation), **12** and not with the blood of goats and bulls but with his own blood, he entered once for all into the ‘holy place (that is, the Heavenly Tabernacle)’⁸⁰, having secured eternal redemption. **13** For if the blood of bulls and goats and ‘the ashes of a heifer’⁸¹ sprinkled on those who were impure according to the Mosaic Law produced holiness with respect to physical purity, **14** how much more does the blood of Christ, who through the eternal spirit offered himself as an ‘unblemished’⁸² offering to God the Father, purify your conscience from dead works ‘so that we may serve’⁸³ a living God?

9:15 And for this reason, Christ is the mediator of a new covenant ‘so that those who have been called may receive the promise of the eternal inheritance, the death of blameless Christ having occurred (on the cross) for the redemption of those condemned because of the transgressions against the Old Covenant’⁸⁴. **16** Where there is a ‘will that is in effect, after all, the death of the one who made it must be evident’⁸⁵. **17** (Certainly, a will is in effect in the case of the dead rather than the living, since it has no power while the one who made it still lives.) **18** Therefore, not even the first covenant was inaugurated without blood: **19** after every commandment of the Mosaic Law had been spoken by Moses to all the people, taking the blood of the bulls and goats with water and scarlet wool and hissop, the book containing the Pentateuch itself and all the people he sprinkled, **20** saying (in Ex 24:8), “This is the blood of the covenant which God has commanded you to abide by.” **21** The Tabernacle as well and all the vessels of priestly ministry he sprinkled with blood in the same way, **22** and the Mosaic Law specifies that almost everything is purified with blood,

⁷⁹ Rotherham “rendering the divine service.” Most translations seem to understand that it is the Israelites offering gifts and sacrifices (through the agency of priests) whose consciences were not perfected under the Mosaic Law. I suspect, however, that the author is thinking of the priests offering gifts and sacrifices on behalf of ordinary Israelites. If so, this thought would be implied: if even priests could not expect under the Mosaic Law to have a perfectly clear conscience, how could ordinary Israelites expect to attain this?

⁸⁰ Probably, given the the wording in the Greek on the one hand and the general sense of the passage on the other (see also verse 24 below), the reference is to the Heavenly Tabernacle as a whole (including both its Holy Place and its Holy of Holies), which is what the ESV and NASB seem to understand (ESV and NASB). Or possibly “Holy Place” is a better rendering (so, in effect, Rotherham). Some translations (HCSB, ISV), meanwhile, understand the reference here to be to the Holy of Holies.

⁸¹ The reference is to the ashes of the red heifer (Num 19).

⁸² The author uses the same word used to describe the red heifer in Num 19:2. The red heifer's purification was a foreshadowing of the greater purification Christ would later offer.

⁸³ So ISV; more literally “for the service of.”

⁸⁴ More literally “so that, the death of blameless Christ having occurred (on the cross) for the redemption of those condemned because of the transgressions against the Old Covenant, those who have been called may receive the promise of the eternal inheritance.”

⁸⁵ In Greek the words for “will” and “covenant” are the same. Now, in the OT few or no covenants required the death of the one enacting the covenant before they went into effect. We do observe, however, that in most or all cases the death of an animal was part of the procedure for enacting the covenant (see, for example, Gen 15). Probably, these animal deaths were recognized as parallel to the animal deaths that took place on the altar – they were substitutions for the actual death of a person. Part of the logic of this passage, then, is probably that the New Covenant is even more trustworthy in its provisions than was the Old, since Christ inaugurated the New Covenant by his own (rather than merely an animal's) death (see especially verse 25 below). (For a somewhat different explanation of the connection between “covenant” and “will,” see *A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament and Other Early Christian Literature*, 3rd edition, revised and edited by Fredrick William Danker and published by the University of Chicago.)

and so without shedding of blood there is no forgiveness *of sins*. **23** It was necessary, then, that by these things on the one hand the *earthly* representations of things in heaven should be purified, but that by better sacrifices than these on the other hand the heavenly things *should be purified*. **24** Christ has *indeed* not, after all, entered into a holy place made with hands, *merely* corresponding to the true holy place, but rather into heaven itself, now to appear before the face of God on our behalf. **25** And *he appears before the face of God* not to offer himself many times, as indeed the high priest came into the holy place every year with the blood of a being other than himself (*that is, with the blood of an animal*) – **26** otherwise, it would be necessary for Christ to suffer many times from the foundation of the world *until the present time and beyond*, but at this point in history, once, at ‘the completion⁸⁶ of the ages, ‘to remove⁸⁷ sin through his sacrifice *of himself*, he has appeared. **27** And just as it is appointed for human beings once to die, and after this is *a time of judgment*, **28** ‘in the same way also Christ⁸⁸, ‘having once been offered one time⁸⁹ to bear the sins of many (*as it was foretold in Is 53:12*), a second time, without *any sin to deal with any longer*, will appear to those who are waiting for him to bring salvation.

10:1 For – *to summarize and explain still further the tremendous difference there is between the Old Covenant and the New* – the Mosaic Law, since ‘it possesses only a shadow of the coming good things *which Christ would bring under the New Covenant*, not the very image of things⁹⁰, could not perfect those who drew near through the sacrifices which they *who ministered in the earthly Tabernacle* offered continually every year. **2** Otherwise, would they not have ceased to be offered, since *in the event that perfection came through sacrifice at the earthly Tabernacle* those ministering in that Tabernacle would no longer have any consciousness of sin because they had been purified once for all? **3** But *there was no such perfection to be found in the sacrifices of the earthly Tabernacle; indeed*, in them they found reminders of *the guilt of their sins every year*, **4** since the blood of bulls and goats is unable to take away sins. **5** So, *to remedy this situation*, Christ, coming into the world, says in Ps 40:6, “Sacrifice and offering you have not desired, / ‘but a body you have prepared for me⁹¹; **6** / burnt offering and sin offering you have not taken pleasure in.” **7** Then he says in verses 7 and 8, “Behold, I have come; / in the scroll of the book it is written concerning me: / to do, my God, your desire.” **8** Now notice: above in verse 6 he says, ‘“Sacrifice and offering and burnt offering and sin offering you have neither taken pleasure in nor desired,” which are *sacrifices* offered according to the Mosaic Law’s requirements⁹², **9** and then he says in verses 7 and 8, ‘“Behold, I have come to do your desire, O God⁹³” – ‘he takes away the first *thing mentioned (that is, the*

⁸⁶ NASB has “the consummation”; the ESV, HCSB, and ISV have “the end”; Rotherham has “a conjunction.”

⁸⁷ So ISV.

⁸⁸ The idea seems to be that Christ, like other humans (the statement that men die is a general rule to which there are exceptions, such as Enoch), has died once and, like other humans, will see a time of judgment. The difference between Christ and other humans is that he will be the judge while they will be the judged.

⁸⁹ While the Levitical priests needed to offer sacrifice after sacrifice, since their offerings were not truly effective, Christ will never again offer himself as he did on the cross, since his offering was truly effective.

⁹⁰ The metaphor is something like this: If Jesus were to stand in a sunny field, he himself would be the New Covenant, while the vague shadow on the ground, portraying his goodness only partially, would be the Old Covenant.

⁹¹ English versions of Ps 40:6 have something like “ears you have dug for me.” Was the author of Hebrews using a different manuscript of Ps 40 than our English versions were? Comparing Ps 40 to Heb 10 is a difficult task, but probably the author is giving us an interpretive translation of the same Hebrew text which we possess today. See app. 6 for more discussion.

⁹² The author reasons that since the sorts of sacrifices mentioned in Ps 40:6 are intrinsic to the Old Covenant, and since Christ there says that the Father did not desire them (in and of themselves), it follows that the Old Covenant was only temporary, to be replaced later by something better.

⁹³ The Israelites never did keep the Old Covenant, but the installation of the New Covenant means the actual performance of those things which really please God (see Jer 31:31-34, which the author referenced above in 8:8-12).

offering of sacrifices according to the Mosaic Law) in order to establish the second thing mentioned (that is, doing God the Father's desire)⁹⁴, **10** 'by which desire of God the Father we have been made holy through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ⁹⁵ once for all. **11** And, on the one hand, every *Levitical* priest stood daily in the *Tabernacle* over and over offering the same sacrifices, which sacrifices can never take away sins, **12** but Christ, on the other hand, having been offered as a single sacrifice on behalf of sins, a sacrifice which will last forever in its results, has no need to stand to minister continually but rather has sat down at the right hand of God (as was foretold in Ps 110:1), **13** waiting at this time until his enemies should be made a footstool for his feet. **14** For by a single offering he has perfected forever those who are being made holy (that is, believers), while, as we have seen, the *Levitical* priests under the Old Covenant could offer no perfection. **15** And the Holy Spirit also testifies to us of the superiority of the New Covenant over the Old, for after he says in Jer 31, **16** '“For this is the new covenant which I will make with them after those days,” says the Lord, ‘putting my laws in their hearts – and in their very minds will I write them’⁹⁶,” **17** there is also this statement in the same passage: “And their sins and their lawless deeds I will be mindful of no longer.” **18** And where there is forgiveness of these things, there is no longer any necessity for a sacrifice for sins, although sacrifices were continually necessary under the Old Covenant.

10:19 Having, then, brothers, the right of confident entrance into the holy places in the blood of Jesus **20** – an entrance which Jesus has inaugurated for us as a new and living way ‘through the veil (that is, his body)⁹⁷ – **21** and having a great high priest over the house of God in Jesus, **22** let us draw near to God with genuineness of heart in ‘full conviction (that is, with faith that God is reliable)⁹⁸, ‘since our hearts have been sprinkled and so clean from an evil conscience, and our bodies have been washed in clean water⁹⁹, **23** let us hold on to the confession of our hope without wavering (since he who promised to give us that which we presently hope for is faithful to do what he promises), **24** and let us consider one another as to how to provoke love and good works, **25** not forsaking our church gatherings (as is the habit of some), but rather exhorting one another, and doing so all the more as you see the day of Christ drawing near. **26** I say this because if we go on sinning willfully even after having received the knowledge of the truth, there remains no further sacrifice for sins, Christ having died once for all, as we have seen, **27** but only an expectation of fearful judgment and a ‘fiery jealousy about to consume the adversaries of God¹⁰⁰. **28** Consider: Even under the Old Covenant, which we have seen to be much inferior to the New Covenant, someone who disobeyed

⁹⁴ Christ was the first human to please God to the degree that will be seen under the New Covenant, and his removal of the Old Covenant (by means of the sacrifice of himself) paved the way for the New.

⁹⁵ In the case of Christ, what was it that the Father truly desired? The total obedience required by a sacrificial death on a cross, a death because of which we who believe have been made holy! (See also 2:9 above and the notes there.)

⁹⁶ The author is paraphrasing the passage (Jer 31:33) he had quoted earlier (8:8-10); as mentioned earlier, paraphrase rather than word-for-word quotation is common in NT-era writing.

⁹⁷ The idea is that just as a veil separated the Holy of Holies from the Holy Place, and thus the veil was the point of entrance to the Holy of Holies, so the sacrifice of Christ's body on the cross is the means by which we can enter the real Holy of Holies (the throne room of God).

⁹⁸ Or “full assurance of faith” (so most versions) or perhaps “the full assurance that faith provides” (ISV).

⁹⁹ Or “making sure to have sprinkled our hearts and so clean them from an evil conscience, and making sure to have washed our bodies in clean water,” or, “having our heart sprinkled and so clean from an evil conscience, and our body washed in clean water,” but 9:13-14 seems to favor the translation given above: Sprinkling there is something that Jesus did for us, and that he did once for all. (The ISV and Rotherham definitely agree with the substance of the main rendering given here. The HCSB probably does as well, while the ESV and NASB seem to favor “making sure...”)

¹⁰⁰ The author may be drawing his wording here from Is 26:11, which probably speaks of God's acts of judgment which will be seen at the commencement of the end of the Tribulation Period. Concerning the strong language used here, see Jm 4:4 (also note *I Clement* 36:5, an early Christian letter which apparently equates disobedient believers with the “enemies” of Ps 110:1).

the 'Mosaic Law'¹⁰¹ died without *the possibility of mercy upon the testimony of two or three witnesses to the effect that the person in question had sinned*. **29** How much severer punishment do you think that person will deserve, *the person* who has trampled on the son of God, and has treated as profane the blood which inaugurated the *New Covenant* in which he has been made holy, and has insulted the spirit of grace? **30** After all, we know who it was who said in *Deut 32:35*, "Vengeance is mine; I will repay", says the Lord," and similarly in 'Ps 135:14, "The Lord will judge"¹⁰² his people" - *none other than God himself said those things*. **31** It is a fearful thing to fall into the hands of a living God.

10:32 But remember the former days in which, after you were enlightened, you endured 'a hard and painful struggle'¹⁰³, **33** at one moment being made a public spectacle both by insults and by afflictions, and at another moment becoming partners with those who were being treated in this way. **34** (After all, you suffered along with my imprisonment *for the sake of the Gospel*, and you welcomed the *undeserved* seizure of your *own* property with joy, knowing that you had a better possession and an enduring one *waiting for you* in the heavens) **35** Do not, then, cast away your *reason for confidence in attaining fully to that rest we spoke of earlier*, which brings a great reward, **36** because you have need of endurance in order that, having done what God desires *in your lives*, you may earn *the full benefits* of the promise. **37** *I implore you to do this*, for in just a very short time, *as prophesied in 'Hab 2:3-4'*¹⁰⁴, '“the coming one will come and will not delay. **38** The righteous one will live by faith, but if he shrinks back *because of a lack of courage*, my soul has no pleasure in him, *says the Lord*'¹⁰⁵.” **39** 'But *I am persuaded, brothers, that we will not be found to be characterized by shrinking back, which would result in the loss of our rewards, but rather by faith, which will result in our souls' gain by way of rewards for service*'¹⁰⁶. *We need to cultivate faith!*

11:1 Now, *to cultivate faith is to cultivate a confidence concerning things we can only hope in (since we do not presently possess them), and – to say it a different way – to cultivate a conviction of things we cannot presently see with our eyes*. **2** For by it those of ancient times 'obtained a good testimony'¹⁰⁷. **3** *Let us consider some examples of how believers from early times on have obtained a good testimony through faith:* By faith we understand that by God's *simply* speaking the ages were prepared, which means that it was not

¹⁰¹ Or possibly, "a single law of Moses."

¹⁰² Most English versions of Ps 135:14 say "vindicate" rather than "judge." The Hebrew word, in fact, is a general term which includes both the dispensing of consequences for evildoers and the offering of help for those who have been wronged.

¹⁰³ So ISV.

¹⁰⁴ English versions mistranslate part of the the verse by rendering the Hebrew with something like "it will surely come" instead of "the coming one will come," doing so because they assumed the wrong vowels for one of the Hebrew words in question (the OT was originally written largely without indications of vowels, leaving the reader to supply them). The Septuagint does contain at least one textual variant with respect to the Hebrew manuscripts on which our English versions are based, the latter incorrectly reading "his soul is not right *within* him" rather than "my soul takes no pleasure in him." There is also a Hebrew word in the passage which is obscure to modern scholars, but probably was better known to and accurately translated by the Septuagint (which translation the author of Hebrews has verified by his use of it).

¹⁰⁵ The author of Hebrews paraphrases with respect to the word order (probably so as to end on a stern note, since he in this passage is trying to alert his readers to grave danger). Does "the coming one" (which could also be translated "that which is coming") mean Christ (coming to judge his people), or does it mean the fulfillment of the vision prophesying Babylon's downfall? I suspect both of these things are in his mind. The fulfillment of the vision concerning the Babylonians would indeed come, but the ultimate example of a prophecy coming about is to be found in the Messiah. (Aramaic-language interpretive translations of the OT often use the term "the word of the Lord" to refer to God's physical presence.) Consider, too, a possible connection with the first chapter of Hebrews: Jesus is God the Father's greatest communication to mankind. (See also app. 7.)

¹⁰⁶ Other versions at least suggest a different understanding of this verse, but a combination of the particular Greek words involved, the immediate context, and the analogy of passages like I Cor 3:12-15 lead me to render as I do.

¹⁰⁷ So NASB margin; Rotherham has "[became] well-attested"; ESV has "received their commendation"; ISV has "won approval" (HCSB similar).

out of visible things that the things which are seen *in creation all around us* came to exist, *but rather all creation came from nothing*. **4** By faith Abel offered a ‘larger¹⁰⁸ sacrifice to God than Cain did, through which *larger sacrifice* he obtained testimony that he was a righteous man (‘God also testifying concerning Abel’s gifts¹⁰⁹), and ‘through which *larger sacrifice* he also continues to speak, even though he died¹¹⁰. **5** By faith Enoch was taken *to heaven* so that he did not experience death, and, *as Scripture says in the second part of Gen 5:24*, “he was not found by other men when they looked for him,” since God had taken him *to heaven* because it had been testified *of him* prior to his being taken *to heaven* that he was pleasing to God *in his lifestyle (as it says in the first part of Gen 5:24)*. **6** (Now, without faith it is impossible to please God, since the one who comes to God must believe that God ‘really is there¹¹¹, and that he is the rewarder of those who seek him.) **7** By faith Noah, having been warned *by God* concerning things which had not yet been seen, out of reverence *for God* built an ark so that his household was saved *from the flood*, through which *ark* he condemned the world and became an inheritor of that *sort of* righteousness which comes through faith. **8** By faith ‘Abraham,¹¹² when he was called *by God in Gen 12:1*, obeyed *the Lord* by going out *from his homeland* ‘without even knowing where he was going¹¹³. **9** By faith he sojourned in the promised land as a stranger, living in tents *rather than ever attempting to establish a city* (along with Isaac and Jacob, *who were* fellow-inheritors of the same promise), **10** because he was waiting for the city which has *truly lasting* foundations, *the city* whose founder and builder is God *himself*. **11** By faith also Sarah herself received the ability to conceive and bore *a son* even though the prime of life had passed, since he considered God who had promised *to give him a seed to be faithful to keep his word*. **12** Therefore, through *just one man* – and that from one *so old as to be* as good as dead! – was born a group of people as numerous

¹⁰⁸ (“Larger” – Rotherham has “fuller” – is probably a better translation of the Greek word used here than is “better.”) Evidently, Cain’s error was not, as is commonly stated, that he brought plants rather than animals to God, but rather that he brought too small an offering, the offering likely being less than ten percent of his crop. The author probably learned that Cain’s offering was deficient in amount (and therefore Abel’s was sufficient – his, after all, was accepted by God, while Cain’s was not) because of the implications of God’s words in Cain in Gen 4:7, “Certainly, if you do not divide *your income* properly *for sacrifice* even though you may offer *your sacrifice* in a proper manner, you have sinned. Be silent *and consider your ways!* Sin’s desire is for *mastery over* you, but you must master it!” (The preceding is a paraphrase of Gen 4:7 according to the Septuagint; the Hebrew manuscripts which have been used by most English versions are probably in error at this point – though not as greatly as might appear from the differences in translation.) Abel, in other words, was looking ahead to the reward God offered in the future for faithful service to him, while Cain was deliberately shortsighted, shirking his duties with respect to the amount that God required. Alternatively, the issue was not a lack of tithing, but a lack of sincerity shown by the amount of the offering being paltry.

¹⁰⁹ The author of Hebrews is probably alluding to the Septuagint’s translation of the Hebrew word “mincha” as “gifts” in Gen 4:4 but as “sacrifices” in verse 5 (see app. 8). Abel not only met the required amount but because of his dedication to God went beyond that requirement in his giving.

¹¹⁰ True, Abel died, but this fact does not keep him from encouraging us to follow his example, since Scripture records his acts of faith for us to read.

¹¹¹ This paraphrase understands the author to be alluding to the divine name (often rendered “Yahweh”), which I think signifies (at least some of the time) not mere existence but rather protective presence. NASB and Rotherham have simply “is” (though one or more of them may mean by that something like what this paraphrase does); ESV, HCSB, and ISV have “exists.”

¹¹² Why does the author call attention to Abraham’s change of name by calling him “Abraham” even though he was still known as “Abram” in Gen 12? Probably because Abraham, in accepting this name from God (Gen 17:5) exhibited faith, since the name indicates that he would be the father of many nations, even though at the time he received this name Abraham had only one son (and that one who, being the son of a slave woman and a sojourner, was unlikely to produce the kings mentioned in verse 6) and was too old to have more.

¹¹³ Gen 12:1 says “go... to the land which I will show you.” Saying “will show” rather than “have shown” implies that Abram did not know what his destination was when he began his journey. We do not need to know our destination when God is our guide!

as the stars of heaven and beyond counting, *just* like the sand of the seashore *is beyond counting*. **13** (Now, in faith all these *OT saints* died, not receiving the promises *in their lifetimes*, but seeing them from a great distance away and welcoming them, and admitting that they themselves were strangers and sojourners on the earth. **14** Now, what I mean is that those who speak in this way – *as men like Abraham and Isaac did* – make it clear that they are seeking a *truly satisfying* homeland *still ahead of them* – **15** and indeed, if they had set their minds on the place they had left, they might have had an opportunity to return *there*, **16** but *they did not do so, and indeed* the truth is that they were striving to attain *an inheritance not within the place they left but rather* a better portion, that is, a heavenly one. Therefore, God is not ashamed to be called their God, because he has prepared for them a city *in keeping with his faithfulness*. (Concerning the fact that *these OT saints did not receive the promises in their lifetimes we will have more to say shortly*.) **17** By faith Abraham offered Isaac as an offering when he was tested *by God*, and *on that occasion demonstrated his faith in that* he who had accepted the promises was offering *none other than* his only begotten son, **18** concerning whom God had said (*in Gen 21:12*), “In Isaac your seed will be called.” **19** He did this, considering that God was able to raise *someone* even from the dead, and for this reason, *having demonstrated such faith*, Abraham ‘received Isaac as a symbol¹¹⁴. **20** By faith Isaac spoke concerning things that were still future when he blessed Jacob and Esau. **21** By faith Jacob while he was dying blessed each of Joseph's sons, and ‘bowed in worship *to God, leaning on his staff*¹¹⁵ ‘(*as it says in Gen 47:31*)¹¹⁶. **22** By faith Joseph, as his life was coming to its end, ‘called *his brothers* to remembrance¹¹⁷ of the *promise God had made earlier* concerning the *future* exodus of the sons of Israel *from Egypt*, and ‘gave orders concerning his bones¹¹⁸. **23** By faith Moses, when he was born, was hidden for three months by his parents, because they saw that the child was ‘beautiful¹¹⁹, and they did not fear the king's decree. **24** By faith Moses when he had grown up refused to be called the son of Pharaoh's daughter, **25** choosing instead to suffer along with God's people rather than ‘to enjoy the short-lived pleasure of sin¹²⁰, **26** since he considered *sharing in* ‘the Messiah's¹²¹ reproach to be greater treasure than all the riches of Egypt, because he was looking ahead to the reward. **27** By faith he ‘left Egypt behind¹²², ‘not fearing the king's wrath¹²³, for he was

¹¹⁴ The author may have in mind the whole incident on Mount Moriah (Gen 22:1-19), or, since he uses the word “received,” he may have in mind specifically the fact that Abraham left Mount Moriah with his beloved son alive. If the latter interpretation is correct, what the author is highlighting is not the fact that the events of Gen 22 anticipated the crucifixion (perhaps he does not do so because this is fairly obvious, at least in hindsight), but rather the fact that those events also anticipated the resurrection (and/or ascension), at which point fellowship between God the father and God the son resumed.

¹¹⁵ Jacob's bow of worship (the HCSB interprets it as a bow of thanksgiving, which may express well what sort of worship it was – although the translators may perhaps have incorrectly interpreted the thanksgiving as being directed toward obedient Joseph) indicated that he had faith in God to bring the children of Israel out of Egypt in the future as promised (Gen 15:13-16). (Compare also the next footnote.)

¹¹⁶ Most English versions have “bed” or “couch” instead of “staff” in Gen 47:31 because they assume the wrong vowels for the consonants of the Hebrew text at that point.

¹¹⁷ So Rotherham (excepting the italicized words).

¹¹⁸ (The orders were that his bones were not to be left in Egypt but rather brought up to the land of Israel when the Israelites left Egypt: see Gen 50:24-25.) For this order to be carried out would require that the Exodus really would occur just as God had said it would, and thus Joseph exercised faith in saying what he did.

¹¹⁹ Perhaps more accurate (but translated into archaic English) is Rotherham's “goodly.” (The Greek word suggests that Moses' parents spared him not simply because he was beautiful, but because he was a gift from God.)

¹²⁰ So HCSB.

¹²¹ Or “the Christ's” (“Christ” being the Greek word for “anointed one,” which in Hebrew is “Messiah”).

¹²² So HCSB (Rotherham “forsook Egypt”).

¹²³ Moses was (at least momentarily) frightened by some of his fellow Israelites, as it says in Ex 2:14. Certainly, too, he needed to leave so that Pharaoh would not kill him (note the words “from the presence of Pharaoh” in verse 15). But trust in God was what drove Moses' actions, not fear. A similar case may be that of Paul, who, when faced with physical danger, would often leave the area of danger (see, for example, in Acts 14:5-7), and yet certainly was a

steadfast as though he were seeing him who is not seen – *God himself*. **28** By faith he observed the passover and the ‘smearing¹²⁴ of the blood of the lamb on the lintel and doorposts, in order that he who was destroying the firstborn would not bring his destruction to them. **29** By faith the Israelites passed through the Red Sea as though *they were passing over simple dry land* (but when the Egyptians attempted to pass over to kill the Israelites, they were swallowed up by the returning waters). **30** By faith the walls of Jericho fell to the ground after having been walked around by the Israelites for seven days. **31** By faith ‘Rahab the prostitute¹²⁵ did not perish along with those in Jericho who ‘refused to believe¹²⁶, receiving the Israelite spies in peace. **32** And what more shall I say? Time will fail me if I go on to speak in detail concerning Gideon, Barak, Sampson, Jephthah, or of David along with Samuel and the prophets, all individuals **33** who through faith conquered kingdoms, ‘administered justice¹²⁷, obtained promises, shut the mouths of lions, **34** quenched the power of fire, escaped from the edge of the sword, received power out of weakness, became strong in battle, caused enemy armies to flee, and performed countless other great acts. **35** Indeed, to list just a few more things that happened because of faith, women received back their dead by resurrection, while others of the faithful saints were tortured to death, not receiving their redemption at that time, in order that they might attain to a better resurrection than a merely physical and temporary one. **36** Others received mocking and floggings, and even chains and imprisonment. **37** They were stoned, they were sawn in two, they were murdered with the sword, went about ‘wearing sheep skins and goat hides¹²⁸, suffering deprivations, trials, and abuse – **38** certainly, these were saints of whom the world was unworthy – wandering in deserts and mountains and caves and ‘the caverns of the earth¹²⁹. **39** And all these individuals obtained a good testimony through their faith, not receiving the fulness of the promise in their earthly lifetimes, **40** God providing something better for us, so that the OT saints would not be perfected without us.

12:1 Therefore, because we have so great a cloud of witnesses (*this group of faithful OT saints we have just mentioned*) ‘as our example¹³⁰, let us get rid of everything that holds us back and ‘the sin¹³¹ that so easily entangles us, and let us run with endurance the race that lies before us, **2** looking at the ‘founder¹³² and finisher of our faith – Jesus, who ‘for¹³³ joy lying before him, endured the trial of having to die on the cross, having accounted shame to be nothing rather than striving to avoid it, and has sat down at the right hand of God, where he remains seated. **3** Indeed, consider him who has endured such contradiction by

man characterized by faith rather than fear. (Martyrdom, then, is something we as believers should count as a privilege should God make it plain that such is his plan for us, but it is not something we should seek for its own sake.) At least two reasons why we can correctly infer that Moses' departure from Egypt was not one driven by sheer terror are first that in Ex 2:11 the wording in the Hebrew indicates that Moses went out among his people intending to take part in their trial (which fact indicates Moses' godly character), and second that while no human apart from Jesus is perfect, Scripture generally intends for us to learn by positive example from the faithful saints it discusses (compare Mk 2:25-26's interpretation of I Sam 21:1-6, which interpretation assures us that David acted appropriately on that occasion).

¹²⁴ So (in effect) Rotherham.

¹²⁵ Josh 2:1, indeed, identifies Rahab as a prostitute. But why does the OT give us that information, rather than simply call her “Rahab”? It supplies this information, as the author of Hebrews seems to be pointing out, to remind us that God's grace can bring about faith even in an especially sinful person.

¹²⁶ This rendering is partly Rotherham's and partly mine; cf. Rom 1:5. Most versions render either “were disobedient” or “disobeyed.”

¹²⁷ So HCSB, ISV (ESV similar); NASB “performed acts of righteousness” (Rotherham “wrought righteousness”).

¹²⁸ Rotherham “in sheep-skins, in goat-hides.”

¹²⁹ So Rotherham.

¹³⁰ More literally, “around us.”

¹³¹ By this the author may mean sin in general, that particular kind of sin to which any given individual is especially prone, or the specific sin the author has emphasized throughout his letter (namely unbelief). (In the immediate context the first option seems the most plausible to me, but the third option is a possibility as well.)

¹³² Compare endnote to 2:10.

¹³³ Or possibly, “in place of.”

sinner against himself, so that you will not give up, becoming weary in your souls.

12:4 You have not yet resisted to the point of shedding *your* blood in your war against sin, **5** and you have forgotten the exhortation which is addressed to you as “sons” in *Pr 3:11-12*, “My son, do not disregard the discipline of the Lord, / Nor give up when he reproves you. / **6** For *those* whom the Lord loves, he disciplines, / And he punishes every son whom he ‘accepts¹³⁴.” **7** Endure for *the sake of God's fatherly, loving* discipline; God is, *after all*, bearing with you as he would toward sons. And what son is there who experiences no discipline from his father? *Surely, all fathers discipline their children!* **8** But if you experience none of the discipline which all partakers of *God's blessings* have experienced, then you are illegitimate children, and not *true* sons. **9** Now, if we have had physical fathers to whom we showed respect, how much more ought we to submit ourselves to the father of spirits, and live *because of our rightful submission?* **10** After all, our physical fathers disciplined us for a short time in the manner that seemed right to them *to do*, but God on the other hand *disciplines us* for our good in order to grant us a share in his holiness. **11** Now, *you should keep in mind that* no discipline seems joyful at the time (no, it seems terrible!), but afterward discipline yields the peaceful fruit of righteousness for those who have been trained by it.

12:12 Therefore, ‘lift your drooping hands and strengthen your weak knees, **13** and make straight paths for your feet¹³⁵, so that any crippled body part may recover rather than become dislocated. **14** Pursue peace with all, as well as that quality of holiness ‘without which no one will see the Lord¹³⁶, **15** being sure that none of you falls short of the grace of God, that no root of bitterness grows and causes trouble, many becoming impure because of it, **16** that there be no evil or ‘irreverent¹³⁷ person like Esau (who ‘for the sake of *something so insignificant as* one meal gave up his own birthright¹³⁸) – **17** after all, you know *from Gen 27:30-39* that even later on, when Esau desired to receive the blessing, he was rejected, since ‘Isaac found no place for changing his mind, even though Esau sought it with tears¹³⁹, *and you might similarly lose irrecoverably what should be firm in your possession if you are not spiritually diligent.* **18** For you have not come to *Mt. Sinai (where Moses received the Law, as Scripture describes in Ex 19)*, something than can be touched, *a mountain wrapped in* a blazing fire and darkness and gloom and stormwind **19** and trumpet-blast and a voice speaking words, *a voice* which made those who heard it beg *Moses to intercede with God* so that they would not hear anything from it again **20** (since the people could not bear *the severity of* the command *which God had given them, saying*, “If even an animal should touch the mountain, it shall be stoned; **21** and, *indeed*, so fearful was the sight of *God's presence on Mt. Sinai* that *even Moses later said of it*, “‘I was full of fear and trembling¹⁴⁰”), **22** but *instead* you have come to *something far greater even than Mt. Sinai after*

¹³⁴ So ISV; Rotherham “welcomes home”; other versions have “receives.”

¹³⁵ So ESV. The author of Hebrews seems to be borrowing wording from Is 35:3, without necessarily commenting on the meaning of that passage.

¹³⁶ The author may have Mat 5:8 (“Blessed are the pure of heart, for they shall see God”) in mind (Matthew was probably one of the first NT books to be written, and so it is quite likely that it was available to the author of Hebrews when he wrote this letter). If indeed he does have Mat 5:8 in mind, notice that he urges his believing readers to abide by the command implicit in that statement: Cultivate purity with respect to God's character, so that you will enjoy the privilege mentioned.

¹³⁷ So HSCSB.

¹³⁸ As William H. Shaulez points out in his *The Romance of the Hebrew Language* (page 49), Esau's words in Gen 25:32 probably do not mean, “I will die of starvation imminently if I do not eat, and so I cannot hold out hope for my birthright in these circumstances,” but rather, “Sooner or later I'm only going to die anyway, so why bother with any birthright?”

¹³⁹ More literally, “He found no place for changing his mind [or, “for repentance”], even though he sought it with tears.” Possibly occurrences of “he” refer to Esau, but since the author of Hebrews is referring to Gen 27, and since in that passage it was Isaac who refused to retract his blessing of Jacob and Esau who wept, the translation given above seems to reflect what the author of Hebrews has in mind. (Note as well that Jewish literature often uses pronouns in what we in our culture would consider a confusing way.)

¹⁴⁰ These exact words do not occur in Ex 19, and so the author may be drawing on an accurate oral tradition that

the Lord had descended on it: Mt. Zion and the city of a living God – that is, the heavenly Jerusalem – 23 and to ‘an assembly of myriads of angels, and to¹⁴¹ a ‘church¹⁴² of the firstborn whose names have been enrolled in the heavens, and to a God who is judge over all people, and to the spirits of the justified ones who have been made mature, 24 and to Jesus, the mediator of a new covenant, and to sprinkled blood which speaks better than Abel does. 25 See to it that you do not decline to obey him who is speaking to you. After all, if they who were under the Old Covenant did not escape when they declined to obey him who was warning them on the earth (that is, from Mt. Sinai), most certainly we will not escape, should we turn aside from him who warns from the heavens! 26 God's voice shook the earth at that time, but now he has promised, saying in Haggai 2:6, “In just a little while, I myself will shake ‘not only the earth, but also heaven itself.”¹⁴³ 27 Now these words (“in just a little while, I myself will shake not only the earth, but also heaven itself”) indicate the removal of all things that can be shaken – all creation – in order that those things that cannot be shaken will remain. 28 Therefore, since we are receiving an unshakable kingdom, we have an attitude of thanksgiving, through which we offer service which is pleasing to God, offering this service with devotion to the things of God and appropriate fear of him, 29 since our God is indeed “a consuming fire,” as it says in Dt 4:24.

13:1 *To offer some concluding remarks – brotherly love should continue to be practiced among you. 2 Do not be forgetful of hospitality, for through it some believers have unknowingly been hosts to angels. 3 Remember those who are in prison as though you were also in prison, and remember those who are suffering hardship as though you yourselves were also physically suffering. 4 Marriage is to be held in high regard, and the marriage bed is to be undefiled. None other than God, after all, will judge fornicators and adulterers. 5 Your lifestyle should not include a love for money, being content with what you have, since he himself said in Josh 1:5, “‘I will never leave you or forsake you¹⁴⁴,” 6 so that we may confidently say with Ps 118:6, “‘The Lord is my helper; I will not fear; / What can mere man do to me?¹⁴⁵” 7 Remember your leaders who have spoken the word of God to you, and taking into consideration the outcome of their conduct, imitate their faith. 8 Jesus Christ yesterday and today is the same, and he will forever remain the same. 9 Do not be misled by diverse and foreign teachings – it is proper, after all, for our hearts to be strengthened by grace and not by ‘matters concerning foods¹⁴⁶, by which those who live according to such food-centered concerns have not profited spiritually. 10 ‘We have an altar from which those Levitical priests who minister at the tabernacle have no right to eat¹⁴⁷. 11 For, to explain how it is that we have this*

Moses spoke these words or inferring that Moses was afraid (if this account is correct, we should translate Moses' words as “I am full” rather than “I was full”). Most likely, however, he is drawing on Dt 9:19, since Moses there expressed a fear which (although coming on a different occasion than Ex 19) was sourced ultimately in a recognition of the overwhelming holiness of the God of Sinai.

¹⁴¹ Or, “myriads of angels, and to an assembly, even to.”

¹⁴² Or, “assembly” (but a different Greek word than that translated “assembly” earlier in the verse).

¹⁴³ Hag 2:6 says more simply, “the heavens and the earth.” The author of Hebrews paraphrases the verse, however, in such a way as to draw out the contrast between what Hag 2 is speaking of and what Ex 19 spoke of.

¹⁴⁴ This is a classic example of applying biblical truth to our lives: We are not Joshua, and our circumstances are not the same as his, but we have the same God as he does, and so we trust that God will stay by our side just as he stayed by Joshua's side.

¹⁴⁵ The speaker of Ps 118:6 is facing death at the hands of his enemies, yet he expresses his trust in the Lord. Surely, then, we should trust God to help us through our money problems!

¹⁴⁶ (So – in effect – ISV and Rotherham.) The dietary restrictions that the Mosaic Law placed on people have ended along with the Mosaic Law, and so great concern over what foods are or are not permissible is a good indicator of false teaching. (See also such passages as I Cor 8:8, Col 2:16, I Tim 4:3, and Heb 9:10)

¹⁴⁷ (Although it may be for the stylistic reason that both this group of verses and verse 9 mention eating that the author has juxtaposed them, note that they are distinct thoughts: In this chapter, the author forgoes any conjunction at the outset of each new thought, as when he says, “Do not neglect hospitality... Remember those who are in prison” rather than “Do not neglect hospitality... And remember those who are in prison.”) The author has made clear that

altar; in the case of animals whose blood *which has been shed for the sake of propitiation of sins* is brought into the holy place by the high priest, their bodies, *according to the Law of Moses (Ex 29:14)*, are burned outside the camp, **12** and for this reason, Jesus also, in order that he might sanctify the people through *the offering of his own blood on the cross*, died outside of *Jerusalem's gate, at Golgotha*. **13** (Therefore, *in view of Jesus' example*, let us go out to him, *so to speak*, outside the camp, bearing his reproach. **14** After all, we do not have any permanent city here *on this earth*, but we seek the city to come.) **15** *Having* through Jesus *this altar*, then, let us always offer up the sacrifice of praise to God, that is 'the fruit of the lips'¹⁴⁸ which confess *the great grace of God's 'name*, **16** and of doing good and fellowshiping *with one another* do not be forgetful since¹⁴⁹ with such sacrifices God is pleased. **17** Be obedient and submissive to your leaders, since they look after your souls as those who must give an account *of your spiritual life*, so that they may do this with joy rather than grief, as that would be unprofitable for you. **18** Pray for us, for we are confident that we have a clean conscience, desiring to conduct ourselves appropriately in every way, **19** but I urge you all the more to pray, so that I may quickly be restored to you.

13:20 May the God of peace, who raised from the dead the great shepherd of the sheep in the blood of the New Covenant, our lord Jesus, **21** equip you in every good work so that you do his desire, for his own sake working in you to be pleasing before him through Jesus Christ – to whom be the glory into the ages of the ages. Amen!

13:22 I exhort you, brothers, to bear with this word of exhortation, for 'I have indeed written to you briefly'¹⁵⁰. **23** You know that the brother Timothy has been released *from prison*, and if he is going *to see you* soon, I will go with him. **24** Greet all your leaders and all the saints. Those from Italy greet you. **25** Grace be with all of you. Amen!

(For appendixes, see endnote¹⁵¹.)

the OT sacrificial system is no longer needed, since Christ's death was a once-for-all satisfaction of the father's wrath toward sin. He is surely not, then, thinking of a physical altar. No, as he will shortly explain, he means that we have an opportunity to participate in God's worship – through praising his name, doing good, and fellowshiping together – which in quality or degree was unavailable to OT saints (even priests, who in the Tabernacle and Temple probably spent more in time in service to the Lord than anyone else did).

¹⁴⁸ The words may draw on Is 57:19 (a passage drawn on in Eph 2:17) or Hos 14:2.

¹⁴⁹ So the ESV seems to understand. Rotherham seems to understand something like, "name. But of doing good and of fellowshiping *with one another* do not be forgetful, *thinking that verbal thanksgiving to God is a sufficient response to his great grace*, since."

¹⁵⁰ A survey of the notes to this paraphrase will show that the author of Hebrews could have said much more than he did.

¹⁵¹ **Appendix 1** Ancient Jewish approach to interpretation differs somewhat from those to which more modern interpreters are generally inclined. Here are some examples of approaches more or less distinct to Jewish interpreters: In some cases they would observe that an uncommon word occurred in two different passages and accordingly view concepts which are explicitly stated in one of those passages as implied in the other (we do tend to recognize that if two passages are similarly worded, they probably express related ideas, but we tend to recognize such relationships only in the most obvious cases). Jewish interpreters would try to be attentive to the larger purpose God had in mind when he put something in Scripture (as when Paul in I Cor 9:9-10 sees in Deut 25:4 an intent to evoke fair treatment among humans even though the letter of the law speaks of animals rather than humans, or when the author of Hebrews in 9:8 sees in the layout of the Tabernacle an anticipation of a later, better reality). Jewish interpreters would draw applications from what a Scriptural statement only implies more readily than we tend to (as when Jesus in Mat 22:31-32 cites Ex 6:3, which is not a passage which discusses the reality of resurrection but which implies it). In short, seeing how NT interpretation of the OT dovetails so often with Jewish methods of interpretation helps us understand both testaments. However, a word of caution is in order: The NT by no means adopts the sorts of interpretation found in such works as the Talmud and the midrashim wholesale, and in fact it warns against certain practices toward which many people (probably Jews in particular) were inclined in the first century. See I Tim 1:3-11, 6:3-5, II Tim 2:14-19, and Tit 1:10-16. The fights over words mentioned does not

mean paying close attention to the very words of Scripture – Paul himself, after all, does this in Gal 3:16 – but bizarre theories spun out from twisted interpretations of words. These theories abound in the Jewish literature just mentioned, as do mythical stories and calls for restrictions on behavior that God has not called for and which will not aid in our sanctification. For this reason I would caution readers against delving into Jewish literature too deeply. See also Col 2.

Appendix 2 If we were familiar only with Mt 1:23 and we read Is 7:14 for the first time, we might think that Isaiah's prophecy in that place concerned only Jesus (who was to be born around 700 years later). However, verse 16 relates that before the child named Immanuel grew to maturity the kings of Israel and Syria (or Aram, which is another way to translate the Hebrew word which the ESV renders “Syria”) would be defeated, and this event occurred within a few years of Isaiah's meeting with Ahaz. Is 8:8 similarly addresses Immanuel but speaks of an event which occurred long before Christ came. The Hebrew word often translated “virgin” in 7:14, meanwhile, probably means a young woman of childbearing age (whether a virgin or a young wife), and the word which the Septuagint and Matthew use to translate it is comparable in its possible meaning (see, for example, *A Greek and English Lexicon of the New Testament* by Edward Robinson, Harper & Brothers, 1876). Probably, then, Isaiah and his young wife (Isaiah himself probably began prophesying at a young age, given the great span of time during which he prophesied) had three sons during Ahaz's reign (Shear-jashub, Immanuel, and Maher-shalal-hash-baz), all of whose names signified events soon to take place. Immanuel's name signified that however frightening was the military threat of invasion by the Israelites and Syrians, God has not abandoned his people. This reassurance, however, as important as it was in those difficult times, foreshadowed something still greater: the very son of God would one day be born not just of a young woman but of a virgin and would quite literally be God among men. Jesus, in other words, would prove to be the ultimate Immanuel. See also app. 3. (That Isaiah's son, Immanuel, bears a name the significance of which is ultimately fulfilled in Christ is not relevant to the present discussion in the book of Hebrews; note that the author of Hebrews constructs his sentence in such a way that Isaiah's words – not Immanuel's – are put in Christ's mouth.)

Appendix 3 It seems that in history (as the Bible accurately records and interprets it) one event or concept often proves to anticipate a larger, fuller expression of what the other event or concept entails. I will supply two examples, the first somewhat speculative and the second more certain. First, Joel 1-2 seems to describe a locust swarm threatening OT Israel, and describes the coming onslaught as “the day of the Lord,” even though elsewhere “the day of the Lord” seems to refer to the final moments of history. Probably, the devastation caused by the locust swarm, as great as it was, would (had it occurred – in fact, Israel's repentance led God to avert the disaster) prove to be an anticipation of the still greater devastation to be seen in the Tribulation Period. The people at that time, in other words, faced the prospect of a little day of the Lord, while the earth presently awaits the great day of the Lord. Second, Luke 22:16-18 describes the meal which Jesus ate with his disciples as an event which (although in itself very significant, as in it Jesus noted that with his offering of himself as the lamb of God he would shortly inaugurate the New Covenant) anticipates another meal (perhaps the marriage supper of the lamb) to be partaken of in none other than the kingdom of God. (This phenomenon of one event anticipating a greater one I have a hard time seeing in modern literature, although the literary device of foreshadowing may be closely related to it. I suspect, though, that ancient people whose minds had had less exposure to the decaying effects of sin on the world – notice the gradually decreasing lifespans of people in the OT, the surprising degree of knowledge of God seen in people who had few or no books of the Bible, such as Job, and Rom 8:22 – were more aware of this phenomenon. One possible example of this awareness is the way in which books 1-4 of the *Odyssey* anticipate Odysseus' great voyage and dangerous return home with Telemachus' small voyage.)

Appendix 4 The Septuagint (LXX) is a translation—or, more accurately, is a group of translations by various people and in different styles—of the Hebrew and Aramaic OT into Greek, done about 200 years before Christ. When the NT quotes the OT, it very often quotes the LXX translation, which must mean that the LXX was (at least on the whole) a useful translation. Also, the LXX would seem to contain in its built-in commentary information not contained in the OT but nevertheless true (such as when it says that David wrote Ps 95, or, as Pastor Alan Brown has pointed out, when it says in Ex 16:33 – with the support of Heb 9:4 – that the urn into which Aaron put some manna was golden). It can also be of aid in determining the exact wording of the OT when manuscripts vary, since it was translated from some very ancient Hebrew MSS. The LXX, then, is an important document to study. However, I would urge readers not to exaggerate its importance. First, II Tim 3:16 says that Scripture is inspired, but it does not say that translations or copies of Scripture are. While the original Bible in Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek, being a product of God, was perfect, translations made by humans may contain inaccuracies (and languages

other than the originals may in the end be incapable of fully communicating all the nuances of the original) and copies made by humans may contain errors (hence the need to examine different copies of Scripture to determine which manuscripts in any given case represent the original). Also, the NT writers (including the author of Hebrews) frequently depart from its wording (and in at least one case – Eph 4:8 – differ from it in very important ways). Finally, it may be the case that NT writers tended to use the LXX because it was the only Greek version of the OT then available. So students of the original languages should benefit from its translation of the Hebrew and Aramaic but be aware that inaccuracies probably exist in it, and students the Word in general may benefit from its commentary but should be aware that when its commentary is not verified by the NT (as in the case of David's authorship of Ps 95 or the nature of the urn) it may be incorrect. (Also note that while on occasion the Bible cites documents or oral traditions now lost to us, it also says in II Tim 3:15-17 that Scripture gives us everything we need for godly living, and so we do not need to search for other material, however ancient or seemingly spiritual in nature, to supplement our spiritual understanding. In this connection note as well Heb 7:3 above and notes on it where we see the author of Hebrews deriving truth from how little Scripture says about a subject.)

Appendix 5 Some additional thoughts on this topic may be in order. First, the fact that we, if faithful, will imitate God with respect to his rest may be implicit in Gen 1-2 even before Ps 95 comes into consideration, for we were made in the image of God so that we may administer a portion of his creation, as it says in Gen 1:26. Second, Gen 1 emphasizes that God did his works well, which implies that we should do our own works well (see verse 31). (The author of *I Clement* similarly observes in 33:1-8 that as God rejoices in his works – see Ps 104:31 – we who have been made in the image of God should similarly pursue the accomplishment of good works with enthusiasm.) As we pursue this goal, we have Jesus as our role model, who, despite all the weaknesses of a human body and the severest of trials besetting him, strove to accomplish what tasks God the Father had set before him and finished them. Third, bringing these passages to bear on the future may refine our understanding of it, though I do not claim to understand these issues fully. Specifically, while God has interacted crucially and dramatically with humanity (and other parts of the universe, as passages like Job 38:26 intimate) after its creation, it would seem that in an important sense he finished his work in the creation week. Perhaps we likewise, though having much to do in the future life, will look back on the present life as having been our key task. In any case, notice that while Lk 19:11-27 should generate excitement about the future life, its emphasis is on our diligence in the present one, and we should not think that the fact that we will live eternally means that our present lives do not matter.

Appendix 6 Among witnesses to the text of Ps 40, only Heb 10 and key manuscripts of the LXX give any indication that the text may have originally been something other than (literally) “ears you have dug for me.” And in fact, “but a body you have prepared for me” is probably an interpretive translation of “ears you have dug for me” rather than an actual textual variant. The poetic line before and the poetic line after the one in discussion concern sacrifice, and so the norms of Hebrew parallelism (Ps 40 is, obviously, a Hebrew poem) would suggest that the middle line, too, concerns sacrifice. Furthermore, the relationship of our line to the one before and the one after is somewhat parenthetical, and this is the case similarly with the line “in the scroll of the book it is written concerning me” in relation to the lines immediately before and after it (as indeed the author of Hebrews will show in his compressed quotation in 10:9).

Appendix 7 When the Lord says in Hab 2:4 “the righteous one shall live by his faith,” does he mean that one gains eternal life by means of faith in Christ, or that one lives the Christian life most properly by a continuing exercise of trust in God? Once again, I think the answer is, “Yes,” though for a different reason than is the case with respect to Hab 2:3 or Ps 8. The words “the righteous one shall live by his faith” aptly describe both realities. Almost certainly the Lord was focusing on the latter concept in Hab 2, as was the author of Hebrews in 10:38. Paul, however, was correct in seeing the first concept as implicit when he wrote Rom 1:17 and Gal 3:11. (In fact, Paul's logic in Gal 3:2 is probably reversible: it makes no sense to suppose that a life that began by faith and not by one's own efforts should proceed by the enabling of one's own efforts merely, and it similarly makes no sense to suppose that a life that is properly lived only in an ongoing relationship of trust in God would have begun other than by simple faith in God.)

Appendix 8 It is possible that there is a textual variant in verse 5 and that a word other than “mincha” originally appeared there. However, the evidence seems to be that there is no textual variant in that place, but rather that the LXX is offering an interpretive translation (which in this case the NT has verified). It probably derives this interpretation from a comparison of verse 3 and the first half of verse 4: Cain brought one thing, while Abel brought one thing “and” another (had the word “and” not been present, it might have seemed that Abel brought one one thing, namely the fat portions of the firstborn of his flock). (Or the LXX may derive its interpretation from the

words “, he also” which – if we translate literally – come after the word “and Abel”: since “and” has already been said, the words “he also” were included to demonstrate some notable addition Abel made to the sacrifice.)